



Hindustan Times

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SC clears way for probe of attacks on students, cops

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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Tuesday paved the way for an independent inquiry into allegations of police excesses as well as attacks on police personnel during the recent student protests, holding that allegations disclosed a prima facie case warranting a "thorough, fair and impartial" investigation by a high-powered panel, granting interim protection to protesting students and directing the immediate release of all detained minors without criminal antecedents.

A bench of Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and justices Jaymya Bagchi and V Mohana issued notices to the Union government and the chief secretaries of Delhi, Maharashtra, Bihar, Assam, Kerala, West Bengal, Madhya Pradesh and Uttar Pradesh, observing that the competing allegations emerging from the nationwide protests could not be resolved without an impartial, evidence-based investigation.

"The allegations by petitioners make out a prima facie case for an independent probe," recorded the court in its order, adding that such an inquiry must equally examine concerns raised by the families of injured police personnel and the submissions made by the Centre.

The court, however, deferred the constitution of the proposed committee, granting the Union and the concerned states time to place their versions on record before deciding its composition. In the meantime, it ordered preservation of all CCTV footage, drone recordings, body-worn camera footage, wireless communication records and PCR calls, directed police not to release protesters' personal data or digital records into the public domain, restrained authorities from taking coercive action against protesting students even as probes could continue, and ordered the release of all detained protesters below 18 years of age and those who did not have criminal antecedents.

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→MORE STATES WITHDRAW CASES, PG

'Allegations warrant impartial probe': Apex court steps in

Bench says prima facie case made out for independent probe into student protest violence

Weights high-powered probe panel to examine incidents across states

Orders no coercive action against protesting students

All detained protesters below 18 to be released immediately. Order excludes persons with criminal antecedents

Police restrained from releasing protesters' personal data

Orders preservation of electronic and digital records

Signals fresh nationwide guidelines on crowd-control

Issues notices to Delhi, Maharashtra, Bihar, Assam, Kerala, West Bengal, UP, MP



Police diary entry shows pellet rounds were used

Pravesh Lama

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NEW DELHI: At least two rounds of pellets were used on July 20 on the orders of a Delhi Police DCP, according to the statement of a deputy commander of the Rapid Action Force (RAF) recorded in a general diary entry at the Parliament Street police station.

The diary entry — filed at 12:44am on July 22 by a Delhi Police sub-inspector and said HT — is the first document that shows the use of pellets during

the student march to Parliament on July 20.

Dated 20/07/2026 DC Satish Kumar Sangwan deputy commander B 108 RAF salab came to the DO office and said [he] was on duty with Zone I Jantar Mantar DCP North Rana Bhayana on whose orders Non Electrical shell — 55, Electrical — 15, Tear Smoke Grenade — 5, ARG — 28C, ZPP were used to curb the crowd, " said the entry, written in Hindi.

ARG stands for anti-riot gun, BC for ballistic cartridges and PP for plastic pellets.

SC DIRECTIONS CONTRADICT GOVT ASSURANCES: CJP

NEW DELHI: The Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) on Tuesday warned it would resume its nationwide protest if FIRs registered against the agitators are not withdrawn, alleging that assurances given during talks to end the protest are yet to be implemented. In a statement, CJP alleged that the Supreme Court's directions that pave the way for a probe into violence during the protests contradicted the assurances it claimed were given by the Centre on July 25. CJP said those assurances included withdrawal of FIRs and a commitment that no protester would be directly or indirectly targeted for participating in the movement.

→PS

CBI FILES CHARGE SHEET IN NEET-UG PAPER LEAK CASE

Sanjay Maurya

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NEW DELHI: CBI on Tuesday filed a charge sheet against all 13 arrested accused in the alleged NEET-UG 2026 question paper leak case, saying its investigation has traced the leak from the paper-setters to the beneficiary candidates and uncovered the entire chain of the alleged conspiracy. The charge sheet invokes charges of criminal conspiracy, cheating, criminal breach of trust, destruction of evidence, and offences under the 2024 anti-paper leak law.

→PS

Heavy rain brings Delhi weather relief, traffic despair



Vehicles move through a waterlogged road in Connaught Place after heavy rainfall lashed parts of the city on Tuesday.

ARVIND YADAV/HT PHOTO

57.6MM RAIN IN CITY
 With 57.6mm of rain recorded on Tuesday till 5.30pm, Delhi's cumulative rainfall for July stood at 226mm, past the monthly normal of 192.6mm.

TRAFFIC DISRUPTED
 Widespread rains brought traffic to a crawl, disrupted Metro access at some locations, and inundated roads, raising questions over the monsoon preparedness.

DOON ROAD CAVES IN
 A newly constructed approach road to a bridge in Dehradun caved in Tuesday following heavy rains. The bridge and the road were built at a cost of ₹16 crore.

LS BEGINS DEBATE ON PAPER LEAK BILL; OPPN SLAMS 'POLICE VIOLENCE'

NEW DELHI: Parliament resumed business on Tuesday as the Lok Sabha started a fiery debate on a new bill that aims for stricter punishment and time-bound trials for people accused of exam paper leaks. Introducing the Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Amendment Bill, 2026, Union minister of state Jitendra Singh called it "the first of its kind in independent India's history".

Meanwhile, Congress lawmaker Priyanka Gandhi Vadra questioned the formation of the Nandini Nandan task force and demanded that the Prime Minister seek help from education experts and stakeholders to bring a new education policy.

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morestories

Rahul slams PM over Panchayati Raj's appointment →PS

Priyanka accuses Centre of stealing youth's future →PS

Delhi cash aid scheme cleared with 3-child cap

Snehl Sinha

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NEW DELHI: Women with more than three living children will not be eligible for the ₹25,000 monthly payout under the Delhi government's flagship welfare scheme for women. The criterion could probably exclude about 15% of women in the lowest income strata of Delhi's households, according to an HT analysis of the latest data available.

The restriction was revealed after guidelines for the Delhi Lakshmi Yojana scheme were approved by the Cabinet led by chief minister Rekha Gupta on Tuesday. The scheme will also exclude women who use more than 2,400 units of electricity a year — which is essentially monthly usage above the 200-unit threshold for free power.

A monthly financial assistance scheme for women was a key electoral plank for the BJP,

which came to power in the state a year ago.

Under the approved guidelines, women aged between 21 and 60 years whose family income does not exceed ₹25 lakh annually will be eligible for the payout. The scheme has initially been approved for three years from the date it comes into force, after which it may continue with suitable modifications, officials said.

The government estimated a few months ago that more than 17 million women will benefit from the initiative, for which ₹5,100 crore was earmarked in the 2026-27 budget. It is not clear if this number holds in view of the latest exclusion criteria as well as other restrictions that were earlier announced.

Besides women already receiving financial assistance or pension under any other government scheme, those who pay income tax, file GST returns, are government employees, are in the service of a government department, or are in the service of a government department, are excluded from the scheme.

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TEN DOESCHATE, DILIP'S CONTRACTS WITH BCCI LAPSE

Press Trust of India

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NEW DELHI: The contracts of assistant coach Ryan Ten Doeschate and fielding coach T Dilip have ended and the BCCI isn't handing them any further extensions, secretary Devajit Saikia told PTI on Tuesday.

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MISIR BESRA, LAST ACTIVE MAOIST LEADER, ARRESTED

Pravesh Lama

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NEW DELHI: Misir Besra, the last remaining Maoist Central Committee and Politburo leader, has been arrested. CRPF and Jharkhand Police officers said late on Tuesday, Besra, who carried a reward of over ₹1 crore, was held in Tundi-Mandya jungle near the Dhanbad-Giridih border.

FCI sold rice for ethanol 40% below average cost

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NEW DELHI: The Food Corporation of India (FCI) sold rice to ethanol distillers at ₹2,250-2,320 per quintal between June 2025 and June 2026, roughly 40% below its average acquisition cost of ₹3,720-3,889 per quintal, according to a written basis to the Rajya Sabha on Tuesday.

Minister of state for consumer affairs, food and public distribution Nimiten Jayantilal Bamhaniya, replying to a question by MP Ashok Singh, said FCI dispatched 6.35 million tonnes of rice worth ₹14,596.78 crore from its warehouse to ethanol plants over the 12-month period.

CENTRAL GOVT IMPOSES SUGAR STOCK LIMIT ON DEALERS AS PRICES RISE

AND A SURGE IN SUGAR PRICES: The Centre on Tuesday imposed stock limits on sugar dealers — they cannot hold over 4,000 quintals of sugar or retain stocks for more than 30 days from the date of receipt — in a bid to curb hoarding and ease prices ahead of the festive season. The order is effective August 1.

India's sugar prices rose to an all-time high of ₹49/kg on average as of July 28.

→PS

CAQM TELLS PJB, HARYANA TO GET DRONES, TRACK STUBBLE FIRES

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NEW DELHI: The Commission for Air Quality Management (CAQM) in NCT of Delhi has asked Punjab and Haryana governments to start procuring drones for the harvest season to detect crop-residue burning in real time, an official aware of the matter said. CAQM in May carried out a pilot project in Patiala, which found visuals to be clear and accurate, allowing them to pinpoint farm fire incidents, the official added.

A standard operating procedure for using drones is being formulated and will be issued soon, with initial focus to only be around crop burning hotspots in the two states, the official said.

Oman draws up plan to split control of Hormuz

Reuters

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DUBAI: Oman has presented Iran with a plan backed by Gulf states to manage the Strait of Hormuz, including sales-based voluntary fees for using it, a Gulf source and a Western diplomat told Reuters on Tuesday.

The Omani proposals are intended to serve as a basis to end the disruption to trade through the strait caused by the US-Israeli war on Iran.

Under the Omani proposal, Iran would not exercise sole control and fees would be voluntary, the Gulf source and Western diplomat briefed on the matter told Reuters. The system will be analogous to one in place on Asia's Strait of

SEAFARERS URGED TO UP ANTI-PIRACY STEPS

After a spate of ship hijackings, including the recent seizure of MT Asana by Somali pirates, the Directorate General of Maritime Administration (DGMA) on Tuesday issued an advisory warning Indian ships and foreign-flagged vessels carrying Indian seafarers transiting the Gulf of Aden, southern Red Sea and waters off the Horn of Africa to step up anti-piracy measures.

Malacca, where Indonesia, Malaysia and Singapore ask ships to pay voluntary contributions to fund navigation, environmental protection and search-and-rescue operations.

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U.S. AVIATION REGULATOR PLANS BOEING 737 MAX SEAT INSPECTION

WASHINGTON: Operators of hundreds of Boeing 737 Max jets would be required to conduct seat inspections under a proposed directive from the US's aviation regulator because they may not have been properly installed, which could risk injury during an emergency landing.

The proposed directive affects 453 US-registered aircraft, the US Federal Aviation Administration said. It's unclear if operators of the jet in other parts of the world are also affected, though regulators in other markets typically follow FAA's lead.

Boeing said in a statement Tuesday that it issued guidance to operators on this issue in December 2025 and that it supports the FAA's making that guidance mandatory.

{ GLASGOW GAMES }

India's medal haul at CWG balloons: 1st para gold in shot put, silvers for lifting, high-jump

HT Correspondent

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NEW DELHI: An inspired show from high jumper Sarvesh Kumar and para shot putters Sharmila Dhanekar and Shilpa K Shyla in the F57 category meant India enjoyed its most successful day at the Commonwealth Games in Glasgow late Monday.

In weightlifting, 22-year-old Valluri Ajaya Babu narrowly missed out on gold in the men's 79kg event, claiming silver, as India's medal tally swelled to 10/2 gold, 5 silver, 3 bronze.

Kushare cleared 225m on his third attempt to become the first Indian to win a CWG silver in high jump, bettering Tejashwin Shankar's bronze from Birmingham 2022. Tejashwin had to withdraw after just one attempt because of a knee injury. He was, however, seen with Kushare on



(Clockwise from above) Sharmila Dhanekar and Shilpa K Shyla; Kushare; and Valluri Ajaya Babu.

the bench, egging him on. In para shot put, Dhanekar hurled the 3kg iron ball to 9.81m, becoming India's first gold medalist.

list in para athletics at CWG. Her season-best effort also made her the first Indian woman to win a para athletics medal at the Games. Compatriot Shyla was awarded bronze (7.26m) following a protest. Nigeria's Ekechika Iyiah was third before her final attempt was ruled a foul after Sharmila drew the attention of the officials, leading to Shyla's elevation.

The boxers assured India of at least two more medals with Preeti Sai Pawar winning her 54kg quarter-final against Northern Ireland's Nicole Clyde 5-0 and Priya Ghanghas (60kg), who won gold at the Asian Championships in April, also entering the semi-final by overcoming Niamh Mitchell of Scotland by a 4-1 split decision.

WORLD | 7.1 MAGNITUDE QUAKE

Several trapped in Japan mall collapse



Emergency responders searched early

Wednesday for people feared trapped in a shopping mall in Japan after a major earthquake toppled buildings, sparked fires and reportedly killed one person and injured more than 100. Private broadcaster TBS reported that a "considerable number" of people were feared dead inside the mall in the town of Kashima after the fire brigade said that the second floor collapsed in the 7.1-magnitude tremor on Tuesday afternoon. As night fell, regional officials said they believed 10 people were unaccounted for in the mall, public broadcaster NHK reported. It earlier cited police as saying between 20 and 30 of the mall's employees could not be contacted. Police told AFP earlier that they could not confirm any fatalities inside the badly damaged building. Kyodo News reported that four people had been taken to hospital, all of them conscious.

BUSINESS | 2ND CO TO HIT LANDMARK

Apple m-cap briefly surges beyond \$5tn



Apple's market capitalisation briefly surpassed \$5 trillion for the first time on Tuesday, making it only the second company ever to achieve that milestone after Nvidia. At a session high of \$342.89, Apple's market value stood at \$5,036 trillion. The iPhone maker became the most valuable company in the world earlier this month, overtaking giant Nvidia - which had been at the top since June 2025 and was the first company ever to breach the \$5 trillion threshold. For Apple, this year's rally has been driven as much by strong demand for its products as its decision to sit out the AI spending race that is sapping cash flows at Big Tech rivals. Including session gains, Apple stock has jumped 24% so far this year, widely outperforming the other six of the "Magnificent 7" cohort of US tech stocks.

REUTERS

COMMONWEALTH GAMES 2026
INDIANS IN ACTION TODAY

BOWLS

Men's 1st Round 2

India vs Namibia (8.35pm)

Women's singles Round 2

Nayamoni Saita vs Caroline

Whitehead, IOM (11:00am, Thursday)

ATHLETICS

Men's shot put qualifying

Ajaydeep Singh Toli, Samardip Singh Gull (3.35pm)

Men's 200m Round 1

Animesh Kujur (4.02pm)

Men's long jump final

Lokesh Sathyanathan, M Sreesankar (11.54pm)

Men's 400m hurdles Round 1

Yashas Palaksha, Santhosh

Tamiliraman (12.03pm, Thursday)

Women's shot put final

Manpreet Kaur (2.31pm, Thursday)

Para Men's 100m T47 Final

M Mohammed Said and Dilip

Gavitt (1.24pm, Thursday)

Women's 3000m Steeplechase

Final: Parul Choudhary 2.05pm, Thu

SWIMMING

Men's 200m Freestyle Heats

Sajan Prakash, Anesh Gowda

(3:12pm)

Para Men's 50m Freestyle S7 Heats

Suryash Jadhav, Chaitanya

Kulkarni (3.44pm)

WEIGHTLIFTING

Women's 77kg: Sanjana (2.00pm)

BOXING

Women's 51kg Quarter-final

Sakshi vs C Fryers, NIR (4.45pm)

Women's 70kg Quarter-final

Arundhati Choudhary vs

M Henderson, NZL (5.30pm)

Men's 50kg Quarter-final

Sachin vs J Morent, BOT (6.35pm)

Men's 80kg Quarter-final

Arkhush vs J Micoic, SEY (7:00pm)

Men's 90+ kg Quarter-final

Narender vs M Seko, SAM (7:30pm)

Women's 57kg Quarter-final

Jasmine vs E Glynn, ENG (11:00pm)

WORLD | NO INDIAN AUTHORS LISTED

UK authors dominate Booker Prize longest



British authors dominate this year's Booker Prize longest released on Tuesday and made up of 13 worldwide books written in English, a selection that "rewards risk" in great fiction writing. Indian authors are conspicuous by their absence in the so-called "Booker Dozen" this year, which includes books by past winners Marlon James and Douglas Stuart in the running alongside previously shortlisted Elizabeth Strout and three debut novelists. The coveted literary prize worth 50,000 pounds is designed to reward and celebrate world-class writing talent. The Shadow of the Object by Mexican-British author Chloe Aridjis, 'The End of Everything' by M John Harrison, 'Black Bag' by Luke Kennard, 'May We Feed the King' by Rebecca Perry, and 'The Palm House' by Gwendoline Riley feature in the 2026 longest.

PTI

SPORT | PRIVATE FUNDING

Fifa plans investment with \$20bn vehicle



Football's global governing body is working with JPMorgan Chase & Co. on plans to raise as much as \$4.2 billion from external investors, with Joshua Kushner's Thrive among the potential backers, according to a person familiar with the matter. FIFA is preparing to open itself to outside investment for the first time as it seeks to capitalise on the commercial momentum generated by the World Cup. The football body is working with JPMorgan on plans to establish a new vehicle holding its media and commercial rights, including broadcasting and sponsorship assets. The proposed entity will initially be valued at \$20 billion, the person added. FIFA is considering raising up to \$4.2 billion from external investors in what would be a significant departure from its traditional funding model. European soccer body UEFA criticised the plan. "It is not FIFA's to sell," it said. "None of us are the owners of football."

AGENCIES

Advisory issued over piracy risk in Gulf of Aden

Yogesh Naik

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MUMBAI: After a spate of ship hijackings, including the recent seizure of MT Asana by Somali pirates, the Directorate General of Maritime Administration (DGMA) on Tuesday issued an advisory warning Indian ships and foreign-flagged vessels carrying Indian seafarers transiting the Gulf of Aden, southern Red Sea and waters of the Horn of Africa to step up anti-piracy measures.

The circular cites the latest piracy incident involving MT Asana, which was hijacked by armed pirates on July 17 while transiting the Gulf of Aden about 65 nautical miles south of Al Mukalla, Yemen. The vessel had 22 crew members, including 11 Indian seafarers, and is reported to be heading towards Somalia with the crew held hostage. A senior DGMA official said the shipowners are in contact with the pirates and all crew members are safe.

The advisory lists five recent piracy incidents, saying they demonstrate that the threat in the Gulf of Aden and adjoining waters remains significant and underscores the need for strict compliance with internationally accepted ship security measures while transiting piracy-prone areas. It cites the July 1 attack on MV Golden Arsenal as an example of how vigilance can prevent a hijacking. The crew maintained an effective lookout, promptly activated the ship security plan, secured themselves in the citadel, established timely communication with the Indian Navy and other maritime security authorities, and followed prescribed emergency procedures. The Indian Navy subsequently boarded and sanitised the vessel, enabling it to resume its voyage safely.

The DGMA said the incident highlighted the importance of vigilant watchkeeping, early detection of suspicious activity and strict adherence to establish

ADVISORY CITES PIRACY INCIDENT INVOLVING MT ASANA, WHICH WAS HIJACKED BY ARMED PIRATES ON JULY 17 WHILE TRANSITING THE GULF OF ADEN

lished security procedures in preventing hijackings and ensuring crew safety. According to people aware of the matter, the Indian Navy continues to deploy warships for anti-piracy patrols in the region. Last week, a Mumbai court convicted 44 Somali pirates for hijacking MV Ruen and Al Kambur in March 2024.

The advisory directs shipowners, operators, masters, Company Security Officers (CSOs) and Recruitment and Placement Service Licence (RPSL) agencies to maintain a proper lookout and remain vigilant. In the event of a piracy attack, crews have been advised to secure themselves in the citadel and immediately establish communication to seek shore-based assistance. The DGMA has also directed crews to conduct comprehensive ship security risk assessments before entering High-Risk Areas (HRA), ensure Ship Security Plans are updated and effectively implemented, register vessel transits with relevant maritime security reporting centres, and maintain regular reporting.

The advisory further asks crews to ensure that citadel arrangements, emergency communication systems, access controls, lookout arrangements and anti-boarding measures are fully operational before entering high-risk areas. Crews should also conduct piracy drills and security briefings to ensure all personnel are familiar with emergency response procedures.

Ukraine: Ship with 13 Indian crew trapped in port hit by missiles

Yogesh Naik

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MUMBAI: The Directorate General of Maritime Administration (DGMA) on Tuesday said all crew members aboard MV Amir al, a Tanzanian-flagged general cargo vessel stranded at Ukraine's Chornomorsk port, are safe despite missile strikes in the vicinity. The vessel has 15 crew members, including 13 Indian seafarers.

The assurance came after the Forward Seamen Union of India (FSUI) said the crew was trapped in a "terrible and life-threatening situation" in the Black Sea and wanted to sign off. The union, noting that five Indian seafarers have died in two separate incidents in the Black Sea, posted a video purportedly showing smoke near

the vessel and alleged that repeated drone and missile attacks were taking place in its immediate vicinity. In a message to the DGMA on Tuesday, the crew said a ballistic missile had struck a warehouse within the port zone moments earlier. Our primary focus is ensuring the safety of the crew and the structural integrity of the hull," the message said, adding that a formal damage assessment and deck log would be submitted once the security situation permitted an inspection.

In a post on X, the FSUI urged the shipowner, the flag state and the Government of India to immediately ensure the crew's safety and arrange their repatriation. "Indian seafarers must not be left as sitting targets in conflict zones," the union said.

OPEN AI OR CLOSED: A complicated debate

Nearly 150 companies have signed a letter opposing any US crackdown on open-weight AI models — models anyone can download and change. Anthropic did not sign. That split reveals a deeper split over how open AI should be allowed to be.

THE TRIGGER

Chinese startup Moonshot AI built an open-weight model called Kimi K3. It now rivals models from Anthropic and OpenAI. Its release forced Washington to decide how to treat powerful open AI built outside American control.

THE COALITION'S CASE

Nvidia, Microsoft, Google, Meta, OpenAI and nearly 150 other companies signed a letter on Friday. It argues open models should face no new restrictions. Harry Godfrey, who heads the Little Tech Association, said a ban would put hundreds of companies at risk, not just those built in China. Such technology would also be key for countries like India, which do not have domestic foundational models yet.

THE FLASHPOINT

The argument turned urgent last week. Michael Kratsios, the White House science and technology policy director, said the US has evidence Moonshot improperly used American models to build Kimi K3. The method is called distillation — training a new model by learning from an existing model's outputs. Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent raised the idea of sanctioning Chinese firms doing this.

BEIJING'S WARNING

China rejected the claims on Monday. It warned that it would respond to any US penalties against its AI companies with penalties of its own.

THE CONTRADICTION

The coalition's letter defends distillation as a normal way to build and improve models. It says the practice should not be confused with theft. But Anthropic and OpenAI have themselves accused Chinese firms DeepSeek and Alibaba of distillation that broke their rules — the practice the coalition defends.

ANTHROPIC'S DISSENT

Anthropic did not sign the letter. CEO Dario Amodei wrote a blog post on Monday rejecting claims that his company wants open models banned. But he said all models, open and closed, should go through mandatory safety tests before release. His reasoning: once an open model is released, it is harder to monitor how people use it.

WHAT'S UNRESOLVED

Washington still has to decide what the real problem is: openness itself, or specific misuse of it. That answer will decide whether new rules target open models in general, or only bad actors.

Who is most likely to lose as Delhi govt adds three-child cap for cash benefits?

Abhishek Jha

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NEW DELHI: Among the many disqualifying conditions for Delhi government's cash transfer scheme for women — the Delhi-based Lakshmi Yojana — is having more than three living children. This eligibility condition is perhaps one of its kind among various cash transfer schemes for women, including those in operation in other BJP-ruled states. Who is most likely to lose out because of this criterion? We have analysed the 2019-21 National Family Health Survey (NFHS) data to answer this question.

Why look at NFHS data?

The 2011 Census numbers are dated. The unit-level data from the latest NFHS (2019-21) has not yet been released. Our primary focus is ensuring the safety of the crew and the structural integrity of the hull," the message said, adding that a formal damage assessment and deck log would be submitted once the security situation permitted an inspection.

What adds NFHS tell us about share of women with number of living

children in Delhi?

Compared with the all-India average, women in Delhi tend to have fewer children. Only 8.5% of them had more than three living children, compared with 15% at the national level. The data shows, the share rises sharply among poorer households. Among women in the poorest 20% households by asset class in Delhi, 14.8% had more than three living children. The share also increases with age. It was 25% among women aged 45-49 years and 13.5% among those aged 50-59. Viewed another way, 34% women excluded because of this criterion would be from the poorest quintile and 77% of age 35 or higher in 2019-21.

What about the social identity of women excluded because of the children criteria?

The probability of exclusion can be different from the magnitude of exclusion. Among major religions in Delhi, Muslims had a higher share of women with more than three children (16%) than Hindu (7.6%) or Sikh women (4.1%). However, because Hindu women make up 84.6% of women in Delhi, 75% of women with more than three kids are Hindu. A breakup by caste category shows 34% of all women with more than three children are from non-SC/ST/OBC castes among Hindu, 26% are SC, 23% Muslim, and 16% are OBC.

Findings from NFHS 2019-21

Poorer, older women are more likely to have more than three living children, the criterion for exclusion under the Delhi Lakshmi Yojana which was approved by the Bharatiya Janata Party-led state government on Tuesday, data from the 2019-21 National Family Health Survey (NFHS) shows

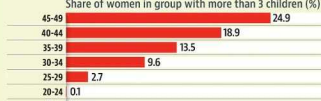
NFHS wealth quintile



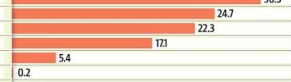
Share of group in women with more than 3 children (%)



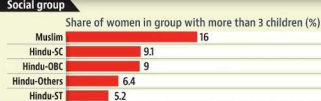
Age group



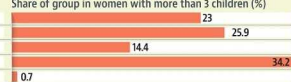
Share of group in women with more than 3 children (%)



Social group



Share of group in women with more than 3 children (%)



Source: NFHS 2019-21

Hindustan Times

MY BENGALURU

EC declines to interfere with HC's timeline for S.R. exercise

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BENGALURU: The state high court on Tuesday declined to interfere with the Election Commission of India's (EC) timeline for the ongoing Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls, saying that the poll body alone must decide whether the schedule allows enough time to complete the exercise.

A bench of Chief Justice Vinhu Bhatru and justice KS Hemalekha disposed of a public interest litigation filed by historian Ramachandra Gaa, writer-activist Devanura Mahadeva, and two other residents of the state, who had sought an extension of every phase of the revision exercise from one month to three months.

The court said the petition was "premature" and that there existed no reason to assume the EC will not be able to address any

procedural issues that might arise.

"The question whether the timeline is sufficient to complete the task is within the specialised domain of EC. It would not be appropriate for this court to determine this issue at this stage," said the court.

The petitioners argued that both level officers (BLOs), most of whom are government school teachers and Anganwadi workers, were under severe pressure. They said many BLOs had received show-cause notices for failing to meet enumeration targets, leaving them with little time to provide the careful, individual assistance required under the EC's instructions. They also cited a few deaths allegedly linked to SIR duty and sought an extension of the deadline.

Senior advocate Vikram Hui-gul, who appeared for the petitioners, argued that the compressed timeline could lead to

THE PETITIONERS HAD SOUGHT AN EXTENSION OF EVERY PHASE OF THE S.R. FROM ONE MONTH TO THREE MONTHS

the exclusion of eligible voters without prior notice or an opportunity to respond, violating principles of natural justice and order of the Supreme Court. Hui-gul said the Supreme Court had held that electoral registration officers (EROs) must scrutinise doubtful entries and issue show-cause notices before deleting names from the electoral roll. He argued that one month each for house-to-house verification and objections left little time for an exercise of this scale. He also questioned whether the 10-day training pro-

gramme for BLOs adequately prepared them for the task.

The petitioners also sought directions to establish voter facilitation centres at every polling booth, publish objective criteria for classifying voters under the "Absent, Shifted, Dead, Duplicate and Others" and "Logical Discrepancy" categories, and ensure that exclusion from electoral rolls does not deprive people of welfare benefits.

Additional advocate general Shashikanth Shetty, who appeared for the state government, also told the court that the state had already flagged similar concerns in a representation to the EC on June 15, 2026. He said that the existing timeline might not allow authorities to complete the exercise properly and urged the Commission to adopt a more flexible approach.

The EC, however, argued that similar challenges remain pending before the Supreme Court

and that the high courts of Delhi and Sikkim had already declined to interfere in procedural aspects of the SIR exercise.

EC also assured the Court that it will issue notices to electors with "logical discrepancies" after publication of the draft electoral rolls and would consider extending the timeline if necessary.

The bench recorded the EC's submissions and said it seemed that the petitioners essentially wanted the court to "fine-tune" the revision exercise.

It also noted that the state government's representation already lay before the Commission and that there was no reason to assume that the EC would ignore it. The bench, however, clarified that the petitioners could move the court again if the EC failed to address their grievances or, if the revision exercise resulted in any "actual violation of fundamental rights."

Cauvery panel orders release of water to TN

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BENGALURU: The state government will discuss whether to file an appeal against the Cauvery Water Regulation Committee's Tuesday directive to release 4,000 million cubic feet of water to Tamil Nadu over the next 15 days with a daily discharge of 3,500 cusecs, a senior minister said.

Speaking to reporters in Bengaluru, state water resources minister K. Ramalinga Reddy said that the government would decide its next course of action after consultations with senior officials and chief minister DK Shivakumar. "There has been no rain here. We need drinking water for the entire year," he said.

The directive, issued after the committee met in New Delhi, is expected to be challenged before the Cauvery Water Management Authority, the apex body overseeing implementation of the Supreme Court's 2018 Cauvery water sharing verdict.

The order came amid one of the weakest southwest monsoon seasons logged in the state in recent years. The state, which depends on the monsoon for about 75% of its annual rainfall, has recorded a rainfall deficit of around 35%. Kodagu, the principal catchment for the Cauvery, has received about 45% less rainfall than normal.

According to government data, the combined storage in the four major Cauvery basin reservoirs stood at 62.31 tmcft on July 27, only 54% of their total capacity of 114.57 tmcft. During the corresponding period last year, the reservoirs held 100.29 tmcft. Storage in the Krishnashankar reservoir fell to about 34% of its capacity.

The state's water resources

[R ASHOKA] L O P IN STATE ASSEMBLY

It is the duty of the state govt to convince the CWMA of the state's actual situation ... and protect the interests of Kannadigas



department told the committee that, apart from Harangi, storage in the Krishnashankar, Kabin and Hemavathi reservoirs remained critically low. Officials argued that the available water would have to be reserved for drinking supplies, including for Bengaluru, and warned that shortages could affect both urban consumption and irrigation.

The state also informed the committee that there was virtually no rainfall in the Cauvery catchment during June, resulting in no inflows into its reservoirs. Although some rainfall was recorded in parts of the basin in July, officials said only a limited quantity of water had been stored and there was no forecast suggesting a strong revival of the monsoon.

"The water available now is limited to drinking. Karnataka is facing a rainfall deficit like the likes of which we have never seen before," the state submitted.

Tamil Nadu maintained before the committee that Karnataka should release 10% of the basin in July, officials said only a limited quantity of water had been stored and there was no forecast suggesting a strong revival of the monsoon. The latest direction follows a

meeting of the CWMA on July 22, when both Karnataka and Tamil Nadu were instructed to confine the use of stored Cauvery water to drinking purposes because of distress conditions across the basin. The authority had warned both states against using the available water for non-drinking purposes.

The regulation committee, which reviews reservoir storage and water releases on behalf of the authority, nevertheless concluded on Tuesday that Karnataka should release 3,500 cusecs a day for 15 days.

Leader of the Opposition in the state assembly R. Ashoka accused the state government of failing to defend Karnataka's case before the panel.

"It is the duty of the state government to convince the Cauvery Water Management Authority of the state's actual situation with correct figures and protect the interests of Kannadigas. CM DK should immediately hold a meeting of officials and lawyers, file an appeal against the recommendation of the Cauvery Water Management Committee and prepare to present a strong argument in favor of the state," he said.

Probe into irregularities in KPSC's hiring of veterinary officers transferred to CID

MB Patil

MIN: LANCASTER UNIVERSITY SET TO OPEN CAMPUS IN BENGALURU

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BENGALURU: Lancaster University, one of the United Kingdom's leading public universities and a member of the prestigious Russell Group, is set to establish its Bengaluru campus, state minister MB Patil said on Tuesday.

At a later stage, the university is expected to establish its campus at the proposed Knowledge, Wellbeing and Innovation (KWIN) City near Bengaluru, he said.

Patil made the announcement after holding discussions with a high-level delegation led by Mark Stevenson, Cross-Faculty Associate Dean for Global Engagement at Lancaster University, which called on him in Bengaluru, according to a release issued by his office.

The minister said Lancaster University is ranked 164th in the QS World University Rankings 2027 and has been awarded an overall five-star QS rating.

The university is setting up its Bengaluru campus under the University Grants Commission (UGC) Regulations governing the entry and operation of foreign universities, he said.

The Bengaluru campus will initially offer programmes in business, management and computing, with the same curriculum and academic standards followed at Lancaster University's UK campus.

Patil said the initiative would provide Indian students with greater access to high-quality international education, strengthen industry-academia collaboration, and further reinforce Bengaluru's emergence as a global higher education hub.

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BENGALURU: The probe into cases registered in connection with the alleged irregularities in the Karnataka Public Service Commission's recruitment of 400 veterinary officers has been handed over to the Criminal Investigation Department (CID), officials said on Tuesday.

City police commissioner Seemant Kumar Singh said three FIRs had been registered at the Vidhana Soudha Police Station over alleged irregularities in Karnataka Public Service Commission recruitments. Two of those cases, he said, have already been handed over to the CID under orders issued by the director general and inspector general of Police.

"The DG&IP has issued orders transferring two of the cases to the CID. The investigation will now proceed under the specialised agency," he added.

Priyank Kharge

THE STATE HOME MINISTER SAID THE TRANSFER REFLECTED THE GOVT'S RESOLVE TO ENSURE AN INDEPENDENT INVESTIGATION

State home minister Priyank Kharge said the move reflected the government's resolve to ensure an independent and transparent probe. "Protecting the sanctity of competitive examinations and safeguarding merit remain our highest priorities," he said.

The allegations centre on appointments to veterinary officer posts, where complainants have alleged that candidates were asked to pay enormous sums to secure government employment. Some aspirants reportedly told investigators that demands reached

₹80 lakh for a single appointment. The inquiry has steadily expanded since July 24, when police registered two separate FIRs over alleged irregularities in KPSC recruitments. One names suspended former KPSC chairman Shivashankarappa S. Sahukar, several commission officials and 29 job aspirants accused of participating in the alleged recruitment scheme. A second case names Sahukar and his two daughters over separate allegations relating to government appointments secured during his tenure as

KPSC chairman. The state government later suspended him.

Job aspirants, veterinary graduates and student organisations have staged protests, arguing that confidence in the recruitment process can be restored only through an impartial investigation.

The state high court had on Monday stayed the criminal proceedings against one of Sahukar's daughters, holding that allegations involving the use of an allegedly false income certificate warranted investigation.

Leader of the Opposition in the state assembly R. Ashoka has called for the case to be entrusted either to the Central Bureau of Investigation or to a judicial commission headed by a sitting High Court judge. He has alleged corruption in the recruitment process denied deserving candidates government jobs.

(with PPT inputs)

MEETING WITH MPs IN DELHI A SUCCESS, SAYS CM

Press Trust of India
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BENGALURU: Chief minister DK Shivakumar on Tuesday described his meeting with the state's MPs in New Delhi as a "major success".

He said the meeting demonstrated that "there is strength in unity" and reinforced the need for leaders across party lines to work together for Karnataka's development.

The Chief Minister's Office (CMO) said the meeting drew an unprecedented response from MPs across political parties and received appreciation even from opposition leaders. Union ministers Pralhad Joshi, V. Somanna and Shobha Karandlaje also attended the meeting.

Anti-encroachment drive



The Greater Bengaluru Authority conducts an anti-encroachment drive on Tuesday.

Man accused of recording wife's death bed scene, police to probe murder allegations

Hirekop Rajan Samuel
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BELAGAVI: A man was detained in Bagalkot district on Tuesday in connection with the death of his 23-year-old wife at their home earlier in the day, said police, adding that the man was accused of recording her final moments instead of trying to save her.

The incident occurred at Gadag taluk, District: Siddhartha Goyal said a video was recovered from her husband's phone, which showed the woman purportedly struggling for while hanging from an iron beam in the bedroom. The footage recovered from the seized mobile phone could be crucial evidence. There is a possibility of recording her final moments instead of trying to save her.

The exact cause of death will be

INVESTIGATORS SAID THE COUPLE WERE GOING THROUGH A ROUGH PATCH AND HAD REGULAR ARGUMENTS

known only after the post-mortem report is received," he said. HT has seen the video. The case in the matter was registered under Section 108 (abetment to suicide) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita.

Police said a fresh FIR would be filed once the post-mortem findings are available.

Investigators said the couple were going through a rough patch recently, and had regular arguments.

edly developed a relationship with another man from the area where her parental home is located.

While examining his mobile phone, we found videos that allegedly led him to suspect his wife was having an extramarital affair. We are examining those videos to determine the circumstances that led to the crime," said the SP.

"The accused shared those videos with the woman's father, family members and some friends. We have recovered those videos," he added.

Police said blood injuries were found on the woman's body and an iron rod-like weapon has been recovered. Officers have also collected evidence from the crime scene for forensic examination.

Beer bottles were also found at the scene and police are examining whether the woman had been made to consume alcohol. They are also recording statements from family members,

neighbours and other witnesses.

Responding to reports that the accused may have made a video call to the man with whom his wife allegedly had the affair, and showed him what had happened, Goyal said: "We have to verify that. We have seized the phone and sent it for data extraction. We will examine the call records, the data available on the device, and recover any deleted data, if possible."

The post-mortem examination will clarify the nature of the injuries on the neck. We are also examining whether she was given any intoxicating substance. Some chat contents have been preserved and sent to the Forensic Science Laboratory for analysis," the officer said.

The incident has drawn protests from women's organisations in the district, which have demanded strict action if the allegations against the husband are substantiated by the probe.

(with PPT inputs)

HT Correspondent
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BENGALURU: The Centre has told the Lok Sabha that the state is yet to submit a formal proposal for Bengaluru's proposed second international airport, despite the Airports Authority of India having completed and shared a pre-feasibility study with the state government.

Replying to an unstarred question from Bengaluru Central MP P. C. Mohan, minister of state for civil aviation Murlidhar Mohol said the Centre has not received any proposal under the Greenfield Airports Policy from either the state government or an airport developer after the study was submitted.

Mohan had sought details on the status of the proposed airport, including locations being examined on Kanakapura Road and Kunigal Road, the land identified at each site, the expected completion of the feasibility study, the timeline for construction, and plans for expanding

The Airports Authority of India has already completed pre-feasibility studies at three shortlisted locations. Earlier this year, state large and medium industries minister MB Patil alleged that the Centre had refused to appoint a consultant to prepare a feasibility and strategy report after the authority completed its site inspections.

A senior state bureaucrat said the government was now waiting for the outcome of a separate techno-economic assessment before submitting on the final location. The Karnataka government has appointed a Singapore consultancy to conduct a techno-economic feasibility study. Based on the final report submitted by the consultancy, the state will select a suitable location and send a proposal to the Centre, the bureaucrat said.

Among the locations under consideration are Kaggalipura, Choodahalli, Harohalli and Somanahalli along Kanakapura Road in south Bengaluru, said officials.

The minister said the existing airport has an annual passenger handling capacity of 51.5 million and an average daily handling capacity of 141,000 passengers. Average daily passenger traffic during the 2026-27 financial year until June stood at about 123,800 passengers.

The terminal capacity at Bengaluru airport is expected to reach 80 million Passenger per Annum (MPPA) by 2030. This is inclusive of Terminal 2 Phase 2 to increase its capacity from existing 25 MPAs to 45 MPAs, he added.

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Probe launched into fake site for govt guest house

BENGALURU: An FIR has been registered and a probe initiated into an allegedly fake website for a state-run guest house that duped people by collecting online payments for room bookings, police said on Tuesday. The FIRs were registered based on a complaint by the senior manager of the guest house, who alleged that several customers received booking confirmations and invoices generated through the fraudulent website and were subsequently duped.

Fruit vendor held for molesting woman: Police

BENGALURU: A man was arrested for allegedly sexually harassing a woman while she was waiting for her cab in Bengaluru, police said on Tuesday. The accused, who was identified as Vijay Raju (42), a fruit vendor and a resident of NRI Layout in Ramamurthy Nagar. An FIR has been registered in connection with the incident, police said, adding that his two-wheelers have also been seized. The matter came to light after the woman shared her ordeal on Instagram on July 27.

GBA to levy fines on owners of unclean plots

BENGALURU: Greater Bengaluru Authority chief commissioner Maheshwar Rao on Tuesday said the owners of vacant sites here would face fines ranging from ₹25,000 to ₹1 lakh if they failed to clean their properties.

He directed owners to ensure that their vacant sites are cleaned by August 15. With the objective of making the city cleaner, more beautiful and more liveable, the GBA will launch the "Freedom from Waste" campaign during August 2026, according to a GBA release quoting Rao.

Hindustan Times

SOUTH REGION

[TAMIL ANTHEM ROW]

TN min boycotts varsity convocation in protest

S Vijay Karthik

letters@hindustantimes.com

CHENNAI: Tamil Nadu higher education minister P Viswanathan on Tuesday boycotted the 33rd convocation of Manonmaniam Sundaranar University in Tirunelveli, objecting to the Union government's directive that placed the state anthem, Tamil Thaa Vaaazhthu, third in the event schedule.

Viswanathan, who is also the vice-chancellor of the university, skipped the ceremony as a mark of protest, while Tamil Nadu governor Rajendra Arlekar, the chief guest, presented degrees to the graduates.

The dispute follows opposition in Tamil Nadu to a February circular issued by the Union home ministry mandating that Vande Mataram be played first at events presided over by governors and Presidents.

As Arlekar, the university's chancellor, was present as chief guest, vice-chancellor professor Dr N Chandrasekar announced at the start of the



Governor Rajendra Arlekar presented degrees to the students.

ceremony that the minister could not attend due to "administrative reasons".

As per the schedule, Vande Mataram was sung first, followed by the National Anthem and then Tamil Thaa Vaaazhthu.

The higher education minister's office later said in a social media post, "as a mark of protest against the vice-chancellor's announcement that Tamil Thaa Vaaazhthu will be sung in third place, the minister boycotted the convocation ceremony."

"The government of Tamil Nadu led by the chief minister

saying Tamil Nadu government events would continue to give priority to Tamil Thaa Vaaazhthu.

"In Tamil Nadu, absolute priority must be given to 'Thamizh Thaa Vaaazhthu'. It is the established practice in all state government functions to sing the state anthem first. While Lok Sabha may follow its internal advisories, extending these practices into educational institutions is completely unacceptable and strongly condemnable," he said.

DMK MP and senior leader Kanimozhi Karunanidhi said, "for the first time in a Tamil Nadu university, the Tamil Thaa Vaaazhthu has been pushed to third place, and the convocation ceremony commenced with the Vande Mataram song."

The issue comes after a political row on July 10 when Tamil Nadu's Chief Minister N. Chandrababu Naidu was playing third at the swearing-in ceremony of chief minister C. Joseph Vijay, breaking from the tradition of playing the state anthem first.

The Governor presented degrees to all 871 students.

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'Govt has discretion to appoint HYDRAA chief

Srinivasa Rao Apparasu

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HYDERABAD: Telangana chief minister Nara Chandrababu Naidu on Tuesday asserted that the executive has the authority to appoint an officer to post, including the commissioner of Hyderabad Asset Response and Asset Protection Agency (HYDRAA), while reacting to the state high court's direction to remove senior IPS officer A V Ranganath from the position over alleged contempt of court.

Ranganath Reddy said the state government has "complete discretion" regarding HYDRAA's functioning and that it would study the high court's judgment before deciding the next course of action.

"The government has the discretion to appoint an officer to any post, including HYDRAA. We will study the high court's judgment carefully and then decide the next course of action," the chief minister told reporters in New Delhi.

Strongly defending HYDRAA's functioning, Ranganath Reddy said the government remained committed to strengthening the anti-environmental protection of the state's water bodies.

He alleged that land grabbers were misusing courts by producing fabricated documents and running misinformation campaigns against HYDRAA.

"HYDRAA is one of the biggest reforms introduced by our government, and we will strengthen it further. Its operations will continue without interruption," he said.



Ranganath Reddy

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The chief minister said HYDRAA was created to protect lakes, ponds, water channels and other public properties from illegal encroachments. He maintained that the agency had acted strictly within its mandate and questioned criticism of its demolition drives.

Referring to recent anti-environmental operations, Ranganath Reddy cited the protection of Bathukamma Kunta and alleged that a senior Bharat Rashtra Samithi (BRS) leader had encroached upon 10 acres of the water body.

He also defended the demolition of structures allegedly built on encroached lands, questioning the opposition's criticism by referring to the demolition of the N-Convent building and constructions on Gandipet lake.

Was N-Convent owned by the poor? Were the structures built on Gandipet lake encroachments by poor people? He asked, arguing that HYDRAA's actions targeted illegal occupation of public land irrespective of the status of encroachers.

Ranganath Reddy alleged that vested interests were spending money to spread misinformation about HYDRAA through social media to protect encroachers. He accused alleged encroachers of filing cases with malicious intent and misleading courts through forged documents.

"We will fight such false cases in the courts," he said, adding that the government would continue to defend HYDRAA's actions through legal means.

The chief minister also referred to former chief secretary Suresh Kumar, stating that more than 400 contempt of court cases had been filed against the retired IAS officer, suggesting that such proceedings were not unprecedented.

The remarks came a day after the high court expressed serious dissatisfaction with the conduct of HYDRAA commissioner A V Ranganath while hearing the Lohitkunda land dispute case.

The court directed chief secretary Sanjay Jyoti to remove Ranganath from his post, observing that it was inappropriate for a senior officer of secretary rank to disregard judicial orders and emphasising that respect for the rule of law was essential to the rule of law.

The bench advised the government to appoint a qualified officer as HYDRAA commissioner, observing that allowing Ranganath to continue would undermine the rule of law. It concluded that his removal was the appropriate course of action under the circumstances.

KSEB WARNS OF POSSIBLE POWER RESTRICTIONS AMID SURGE IN DEMAND

Press Trust of India

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THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: The KSEB on Tuesday warned that partial power restrictions may be imposed during evening peak hours of the day if adequate electricity is not available through the power exchange amid a sharp rise in demand.

In a statement, the Kerala State Electricity Board (KSEB) said electricity consumption in the state has increased significantly due to deficient rainfall caused by the El Niño phenomenon and relatively high atmospheric temperatures.

Said the reliability of power through the exchange has also declined as electricity demand has risen across the country.

With weather continuing in Kerala, the state's power demand is expected to increase by around 400-500 MW on Tuesday compared to previous days, the board said.

"If the required quantum of power is not available through the power exchange, partial power restrictions may be necessary during the evening peak hours on Tuesday," it said.

Kerala has been facing an unprecedented power shortage over the past few weeks. The opposition CPI(M) had criticised the ruling UDF government over the power restrictions in Kerala.

However, the ruling regime blamed the previous LDF administration for alleged mismanagement, saying it also had contributed to the present shortage crisis.

Aadi Thavas festival procession in TN



Devotees participate in the Aadi Thavas festival procession at the Arulmigu Sankaranarayanan Swamy Temple in Sankarankovil, Tamil Nadu, on Tuesday

Vijay writes to PM on Mekedatu, to visit B'luur for talks next month

S Vijay Karthik

letters@hindustantimes.com

CHENNAI: Tamil Nadu chief minister C. Joseph Vijay on Tuesday wrote to Prime Minister Narendra Modi expressing disappointment over Union minister of state for Jal Shakti Raj Bhushan Choudhary's statement that Karnataka need not obtain the consent of lower riparian states for the proposed Mekedatu reservoir, even as the state government confirmed that Vijay will visit Bengaluru next month for talks on the project.

Seeking withdrawal of the minister's July 27 Rajya Sabha statement, Vijay urged Modi to ensure that no administrative approval is granted to the Mekedatu project unless full riparian states' consent is obtained. "This disappointing reply seems to have been made without taking into consideration the prevailing legal position and settled law with regard to the consent of the lower riparian states," Vijay wrote.

Citing the Supreme Court's ruling in the Alambatti case, he said the consent of lower riparian states was "absolutely necessary" and argued that the project could not be evaluated merely as an engineering proposal.

"Its legal permissibility must first be examined in the context of the final award of the Cauvery Water Disputes Tribunal, judgment of the Supreme Court dated February 16, 2018 and the rights of the lower riparian



C. Joseph Vijay

states," he said. Vijay also pointed out that Karnataka's Detailed Project Report, submitted in 2019, had been returned by the Central Water Commission for revision to ensure compliance with the tribunal award. "This itself demonstrates that compliance with the Award remains an indispensable precondition," he said.

Requesting Modi to withdraw the minister's statement, Vijay said the rights of lower riparian states in relation to both the quantum and regulated pattern of water releases must be protected. "Any future considerations of the project shall be undertaken only after comprehensive technical and legal examination, taking into account the concerns of all lower riparian states," he said.

Calling the Cauvery a lifeline of millions of farmers across southern India, Vijay urged the Prime Minister to intervene "in the larger interest of justice, federal harmony and faithful implementation of judicial decisions."

State minister R Vinod said Vijay would visit Karnataka in the first week of August to take up the Mekedatu issue.

"The chief minister is set to

visit Karnataka next month. Right from the beginning, we (Tamil Nadu) have been saying that the Government of Tamil Nadu will not permit Karnataka to construct the dam. The chief minister is going regarding this matter in the first week of August," Vinod said. He, however, did not confirm whether Vijay would meet Karnataka chief minister D. Shivakumar.

Referring to Karnataka's stand at the July 22 meeting of the Cauvery Water Management Authority that it had not released Tamil Nadu's June and July share because of deficient rainfall, Vinod said, "The chief minister will demand Tamil Nadu's share of water for the sake of establishing our rights."

Earlier this week, Vijay chaired a meeting with legal experts handling Tamil Nadu's Mekedatu case, and the government said it would take a decision on the next legal course based on their recommendations.

Meanwhile, AIADMK general secretary Edappadi K. Palaniswami criticised Choudhary's remarks, saying they had shocked the people of Tamil Nadu.

Congress MP Manickam Tagore also sought a clarification from the Centre, saying no approval should be granted to any project that could affect Tamil Nadu's allocated share of Cauvery water or the implementation of the tribunal award and the Supreme Court judgment. The BJP did not respond to requests for comment.



Nara Lokesh

YSRCP HOLDS STIR ACROSS ANDHRA, SEEKS LOKESH'S RESIGNATION

Srinivasa Rao Apparasu

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HYDERABAD: The YSR Congress Party (YSRCP) on Tuesday held a series of protests across Andhra Pradesh, demanding the resignation of state education minister Nara Lokesh over alleged irregularities in the Mega DSC-2025 teacher recruitment process.

In a statement, the party said demonstrations were organised by its student and youth wings in Vijayawada, Nellore, Tirupati, Nandyal and several other district headquarters.

The YSRCP alleged question paper leaks, irregular appointments under the sports quota and denial of opportunities to deserving candidates. It demanded Lokesh's resignation and a Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) probe into the recruitment process.

In Vijayawada, a rally from Sambamurti Nagar to Dharmachowk was led by YSRCP NTR district president Devineni Avinash, former minister Vellampalli Srinivas and former MLA Maladi Vishnu. Former minister Kakani Gowrdhan Reddy led the Nellore protest, while former minister R. Raja led the demonstration in Tirupati, demanding the resignation of Lokesh.

In Nandyal, senior leaders Katsani Ram Bhupal Reddy, Rami Reddy and MLC Isaq Basha led the protest. The YSRCP also alleged that the government was providing timely information, guidance and assistance, a press release said, quoting the CM.

"Naidu directed officials to extend all possible support to farmers facing El Niño-induced drought conditions by providing timely information, guidance and assistance," a press release said, quoting the CM.

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[NERELLA CUSTODIAL TORTURE CASE]

Kavitha seeks stringent action against police

Srinivasa Rao Apparasu

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HYDERABAD: Telangana Raksha Sena president Kavitha on Tuesday demanded stringent action against police officials allegedly responsible for the custodial torture of eight people, including Dalits, following protests against the sand mafia in Nellore village of Sircilla district in 2017.

Kavitha visited the family of Gargham Gopal, one of the victims of the alleged torture, who recently died after prolonged legal complications that she

claimed were caused by custodial abuse. During the visit, she expressed regret over the incident, saying she felt ashamed that it had occurred while she was part of the previous government.

"I bow my head in shame and seek forgiveness because I was also a part of the government when this incident took place," Kavitha said.

Referring to recent police violence in Delhi, Kavitha said the country could not ignore the Nellore case, where victims of alleged state-sanctioned custodial torture had been waiting nearly nine years for justice.

"Eight villagers were subjected to five days of unfathomable third-degree torture. While one was lashed, beaten, or electrocuted, the rest were forced to watch as their spirits shattered.

The torture was so inhuman that the district jailer refused to accept them, and the survivors still haven't recovered," she said.

The incident dates back to July 2, 2017, when a speeding sand-laden lorry allegedly ran over and killed a villager in Nellore. Enraged residents attacked the lorry, leading to a police firing. Lorryes in protest against dangerous driving and alleged illegal sand mining.

Police arrested 13 villagers on charges of rioting and attempted murder. Of these, eight were allegedly subjected to severe custodial torture.

The incident dates back to July 2, 2017, when a speeding sand-laden lorry allegedly ran over and killed a villager in Nellore. Enraged residents attacked the lorry, leading to a police firing. Lorryes in protest against dangerous driving and alleged illegal sand mining.

Police arrested 13 villagers on charges of rioting and attempted murder. Of these, eight were allegedly subjected to severe custodial torture.

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Naidu reviews preparedness for El Niño, directs steps to protect crops

Press Trust of India

letters@hindustantimes.com

AMARAVATI: Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister Nara Chandrababu Naidu on Tuesday directed officials to extend all possible support to farmers facing El Niño-induced drought conditions by providing timely information, guidance and assistance.

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Briefing Naidu on the impact of El Niño and the proposed action plan, officials informed him that the state had recorded a 69 per cent rainfall deficit in July and that rainfall during the next three months was expected to remain up to 40 per cent below normal. Against the normal rainfall of 844 mm between June and November, the state is likely to receive only about 551 mm during the season, according to the release.

Officials said the impact of El Niño was expected to be more severe than earlier projections and could affect all districts in the state. West Godavari, Prakasam, Anaparthi, Krishna and YSR Kadapa are among the districts likely to face acute drought conditions, they said.

Around 2.78 lakh hectares of cotton and more than one lakh hectares of paddy crops are projected to be affected, with paddy cultivation in Sircilla district likely to suffer the highest losses.

Officials directed officials to make optimum use of Vamsadharara river waters wherever available to protect standing crops.

Officials informed him that 122 high-risk mandals had been identified across the state, following which the CM instructed them to explore borewell-based irrigation options in these vulnerable areas.

Officials said awareness campaigns would begin from August 3, with a focus on promoting alternative crops to paddy and implementing an emergency seed plan.

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KAYALVIZHI ALAGIRI ARRESTED IN ASSAULT CASE; RELEASED ON BAIL

S Vijay Karthik

letters@hindustantimes.com

CHENNAI: Kayalvizhi Alagiri, granddaughter of late Dravidan K. Annadurai, was arrested on Tuesday in connection with an alleged assault on a senior official of a public sector bank in Chennai. She was later released on police station bail.

Based on a complaint lodged by State Bank of India (SBI) chief manager Namanyayam, police registered a case against Kayalvizhi Alagiri at Shastri Nagar police station on July 24.

Kayalvizhi, daughter of former Union Minister M. K. Alagiri, was booked under sections 296(b) (using obscene words in a public place), 329(4) (entering a property with intent to commit an offence), 352 (causing physical hurt) and 351(2) (criminal intimidation) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS), a senior police officer said.

Police said the alleged incident of abusing and assaulting the bank official was captured on the branch's surveillance camera. She was released on police station bail.

According to police, the incident occurred after the elevator at the bank branch stopped functioning. The branch manager contacted Kayalvizhi Alagiri, who owns the commercial building, on July 20 to inform her about the issue. Police said she allegedly became angry, verbally abused the manager over the phone and later visited the branch with a relative, where she allegedly abused and slapped him.

"Following this, summons were issued directing her to appear before the investigating officer on Tuesday during which she was interrogated and subsequently arrested," police said.

Despite repeated attempts, DMK spokespersons did not respond to HT queries.

FCI sold rice to ethanol plants below acquisition cost, RS told

Pallavi Singh

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: The Food Corporation of India (FCI) sold rice to ethanol distilleries at ₹2,250-2,320 per quintal between June 2025 and June 2026, roughly 40% below its acquisition cost of ₹3,720-3,889 per quintal, according to a written reply to the Rajya Sabha on Tuesday.

Minister of state for consumer affairs, food and public distribution Nimbun Janyanthilambhambhaniya, replying to a question by MP Ashok Singh, said FCI dispatched 6.35 million tonnes of rice worth ₹14,596.78 crore from its warehouses to ethanol plants over the 12-month period.

Haryana received the largest quantity among the top five recipients at 844.11 tonnes, followed by Uttar Pradesh at 838.645 tonnes, Punjab and Himachal Pradesh combined at 658.952 tonnes, West Bengal at 584.672 tonnes, and Madhya Pradesh at 432.485 tonnes.

Under the Open Market Sale Scheme (Domestic), the price for ethanol distilleries was ₹2,250 per quintal from June to October 2025 and ₹2,320 per quintal from November 2025 to October 2026. It has been set at ₹2,390 per quintal for November 2026 to June 2027.

FCI's average acquisition cost was ₹3,720-3,889 per quintal in 2024-25 and ₹3,889.46 per quintal in 2025-26 (revised estimates). Acquisition cost is what FCI spends to procure rice from farmers; economic cost is the total of procurement, storage, transport and carrying charges until distribution or sale.

The government maintained



FCI dispatched 6.35 million tonnes of rice to ethanol plants between June 2025 and June 2026.

in the reply that no subsidy is being extended to ethanol producers, saying rice is sold at the fixed OMSS (D) price. The reply did not explain the gap between the sale price and FCI's acquisition cost.

The reply also disclosed that two cases of diversion of FCI rice meant for ethanol production had been detected. State food departments had taken action against the two distilleries, and FCI had discontinued further allocation of rice to them, she said. The reply did not name the distilleries.

GN Sood, an agriculture expert and independent director at a listed agriculture company, said the sale amounts to an effective subsidy because the rice is being sold below economic cost.

"The government plans to release 7.2 million tonnes of rice from FCI stocks for ethanol in the 2026-27 ethanol supply year at about ₹23,900 per tonne, against an economic cost of roughly ₹43,100 per tonne," he said. "Unless this is accounted for separately in the Union Budget, the difference will ultimately be reflected under the food subsidy bill."

Sood added that while the government has justified the

move on the grounds of disposing of surplus stocks, the policy raises questions that go beyond stock management. "Rice is already produced with substantial subsidies, is highly water-intensive and is procured at high minimum support prices. The larger question is why such large quantities are produced and procured only to be diverted for ethanol production at a significant cost to the exchequer," he said.

For distilleries, the pricing works backwards from what oil marketing companies pay for ethanol under the blending programme. Madan Sabnavis, chief economist at Bank of Baroda, said: "The pricing appears to have been fixed keeping in mind the economics of fuel pricing."

The parliamentary reply comes as the government pushes to expand ethanol blending with petrol by widening the range of feedstocks, including surplus rice held in FCI stocks. A total of 7.2 million tonnes of rice has been allocated for ethanol production in the 2026-27 ethanol supply year (November-October), up from 5.5 million tonnes in the ongoing year, at the ₹2,390 per quintal price notified for the period, according to FCI notifications.

FCI procures rice at MSP under an open-ended commitment — whatever farmers bring in Punjab, Haryana, Telangana, UP, Chhattisgarh and elsewhere, FCI buys. Procurement has consistently outstripped what the Public Distribution System and welfare schemes can absorb. Stocks have run well above buffer requirements for years — sometimes double or more.

CENTRE LIMITS STOCKHOLDING OF SUGAR TO 4K QTL

Pallavi Singh

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NEW DELHI: Amid a surge in sugar prices, the Centre on Tuesday imposed stockholding limits on sugar dealers, under which they cannot hold more than 4,000 quintals of sugar or retain stocks for more than 30 days from the date of receipt, seeking to curb hoarding and ease prices ahead of the festive season. The government order is effective from August 1 to November 30.

Retail sugar prices rose to an all-time high of ₹49 per kg on average as of July 28, up from ₹46.5 per kg a month ago and ₹46 per kg a year earlier.

The restrictions come as wholesale sugar prices have surged over the past month amid concerns over tighter domestic supplies and lower closing stocks at the end of the 2025-26 sugar season, which begins in October and ends in September.

In addition, a rainfall deficit in the current monsoon season added a premium to sugar prices. During June 1-July 28, the cumulative rainfall over the country was 16% below normal, IMD data revealed.

Sugar's ex-mill price (cost of sugar after it leaves the factory production line) in Maharashtra rose to around ₹42,000 per tonne this month from ₹38,000 per tonne last month.

A senior official at the National Federation of Cooperative Sugar Factories Ltd said ex-mill prices had already begun easing following government intervention.

Get drones to track stubble fires, CAQM directs PB, Hry

Jasjeev Gandhik

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NEW DELHI: The Commission for Air Quality Management (CAQM) in NCBI has asked Punjab and Haryana governments to start procuring drones for the harvest season to detect crop-residue burning in real time, a senior official aware of the matter said. CAQM had carried out a pilot project in Patiala district in May, which found visuals to be clear and accurate, allowing them to pinpoint farm fire incidents, the official added.

A detailed standard operating procedure for using drones, including the number needed to be procured per village or district, is still being formulated and will be issued soon, with initial focus to only be around crop burning hotspots in these two states, the official told HT.

"The pilot project, which was initially planned in three districts, was only carried out in Patiala in May, but was successful. We were able to use drones to get clear visuals from a good height, which can allow real-time action against those found to be burning crop residue," the official said, stating the current challenge was a delay in getting data on crop burning.

State and central governments have grappled for more than a decade with the problem of crop residue burning — a quick and easy way that many farmers, especially those who grow paddy, prefer to clear their fields. But the method sends up clouds of smoke so severe that hundreds of millions of people downwind in Delhi, Haryana and UP have to live with dreadful air pollution for weeks — a crisis that remains an annual affair every winter.

Till now, the enforcement on the ban against crop residue burning rests on data from satel-



Between April 1 and May 31, 9,806 farm fires were recorded in Punjab and 3,398 in Haryana.

lites. "Satellite data submitted to us is a day-old data, as it is from the previous day. The satellites also only make around two captures in a day, during the overpass. Meanwhile, data on burnt area is submitted to CAQM once in 15 days, so by the time we get this information, farm fires in an area will long be over. Meanwhile, drones allow real-time action by allowing teams to go and stop farmers immediately," the official said, stating that over multiple meetings since May, both Punjab and Haryana governments have been asked to start drone procurement preparations.

In the recently concluded Rabi harvest season, CAQM through the Indian Agriculture Research Institute (IARI), monitored farm fire incidents between April 1 and May 31, 2025, with 9,806 farm fires recorded in Punjab and 3,398 in Haryana. In the same period last year, Punjab saw 10,207 fires, while Haryana saw 1,832 fires. The summer season fires are typically not a public health alarm since the season is windier and blows the smoke away.

The count in both states is concerning, since farm fires are typically higher in the winter harvest season between September 15 and November 30. Last winter, in this period, Punjab had 5,114 fires

as compared to 10,909 in 2024. Haryana saw 662 farm fires last winter as compared to 1,406 in 2024.

"The increase in fires this summer is a worry, and we have noticed that while farmers are using machines to remove stubble, the residue, which is barely four inches, is still being burnt as the farmer does not want to till it into the ground, in fear that it has pesticides. As part of our outreach to states, this will be another focus this winter, to make farmers more aware about such practices," said the official, stating they are still working on the specifications and how many drones will be required by both states and who will deploy them.

"The initial plan is to use them only at farm fire hotspots in both states and gradually expand, if required," the official added. Last year, multiple studies revealed farmers were setting fields ablaze much later in the day, thus evading satellite captures and resulting in a lower farm-fire count. One such study, released by the environmental think-tank the International Forum for Environment, Sustainability and Technology (IFOR-EST) in December last year, found this was true across both Punjab and Haryana, with most fires being observed after 3 pm hours when the satellites had concluded their passes. But it also assessed the total burnt area and found it to have reduced by 25-35%.

As part of the study, Sentinel-2 satellite's burnt-area mapping showed the burnt cropland in Punjab fell from 3,447 sq kms in 2022 to roughly 20,000 sq kms in 2025 — a 37% reduction. In Haryana, the burnt area decreased from 11,633 sq kms in 2019 to 5,812 sq kms in 2025 — a 25% dip, the report had said.

INDIA, UKRAINE COORDINATING TO FIND TWO MISSING SEAFARERS: MEA

NEW DELHI: India is coordinating with Ukrainian authorities in the search for two Indian seafarers reported missing following an attack on a merchant vessel in Odesa port last week, the external affairs ministry said on Tuesday.

There were four Indian crew members on the MV AGN Ragnar when it was struck in Odesa port on July 25, and two of them were reported missing. Five Indian seafarers have died so far in the Russia-Ukraine conflict and the external affairs ministry has summoned senior diplomats of both countries to protest against these incidents.

External affairs ministry spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal told a regular media briefing that two Indian crew members of the Ragnar were safe, while a search was continuing for the two reported missing.

"The search is underway for them and the Indian side is in touch with local authorities. We are also in touch with the families of the two missing Indian seafarers," he said. **HTC**

POJK POLLS COVER UP OF ILLEGAL OCCUPATION: INDIA

Rezaul H Laskar

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NEW DELHI: India on Tuesday dismissed elections being held in Pakistan-occupied Jammu and Kashmir as an effort to cover up the illegal occupation of the region and human rights violations, and said violent protests during the polls were an outgrowth of Islamabad's economic exploitation and denial of rights.

About 40 people have died since June in clashes between Pakistani forces and protesters demanding abolition of seats in the local assembly reserved for refugees from the Indian region of J&K. The legislative assembly polls are being conducted in three phases, with the first held on Monday, when there were reports of Pakistani forces opening fire and using tear gas to disperse hundreds of protesters.

External affairs ministry spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal told a regular media briefing that India's position on the "so-called legislative assembly elections" in Pakistan-occupied Jammu and Kashmir has been clear, consistent and well-known.

Bypoll campaigning in Bihar, MP and Guj ends with last-minute rallies

Shruti Kakkar and Subhash Pathak

letters@hindustantimes.com

BHOPAL/PATNA/AHMEDABAD: The campaigning for three closely-tracked by-elections in Bihar's Bankipur, Madhya Pradesh's Datia and Gujarat's Manjalpur, to be held on July 30, ended on Tuesday with last-minute canvassing for votes and parties holding rallies and roadshows.

In Bankipur, in Patna's urban area, the stage is set for a keenly watched contest among BJP youth wing leader, Neeraj Kumar Sinha, political strategist-turned-leader, Prashant Kishor, from the Jan Suraj Party (JSP), and RJD's Rekha Gupta. The poll was triggered by the election of five-term MLA and BJP national president Nitin Nabin to the Rajya Sabha in April.

Kishor has been the talk of the constituency, personally canvassing nearly every street and lane. He framed the contest as a referendum on the NDA government's performance, particularly targeting chief minister Samrat Choudhary, whom the BJP leadership chose as CM after Nitish Kumar stepped down.

Nabin returned to his constituency to campaign, assuring voters that "Bankipur shall remain his top priority" despite new responsibilities.

In MP's Datia, the BJP's



Prashant Kishore at a rally in Bankipur. SANTOSH KUMAR/HT

Ashutosh Tiwari is contesting for the first time while Congress party veteran, Kunwar Ghanashyam Singh, has entered the fray for the seventh time.

The assembly seat fell vacant on April 2, after Congress MLA Rajendra Bharti was disqualified under Section 8 of the Representation of the People Act, 1951, and Article 191(1)(e) of the Constitution, following his conviction in a bar scam.

The campaign for Datia ended in the backdrop of internal dissent for both parties. The BJP faced violent protests in Datia after replacing former home minister Narottam Mishra with Tiwari as the candidate.

The Manjalpur seat, in Gujarat's Vadodra, fell vacant following the death of BJP MLA Yogesh Patel, a legislator since 1990. While the BJP fielded Satish Patel as its candidate, former minister Bhikhabhai Rabhani has been fielded by the Congress party.

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THE WEEK THAT WAS

A quiz on the week's development.

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Sunday Hindustan Times



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Take a cue from the clues

Authors who are not authors, leaders who no longer lead, a beauty queen walks her last walk, and cracks appear in a Hinauch village. More happened this week. Take the quiz to find out



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TWO HELD OVER
PETROL BOMB
ATTACK AT BJP'S
SANGRUR OFFICE

SANGRUR: The Sangrur police on Tuesday arrested two men with alleged cross-border links in connection with the petrol bomb attack on the district BJP office on the intervening night of July 25 and July 26, officials said.

Sangrur senior superintendent of police (SSP) Rajyot Grewal said the arrests were based on human and technical intelligence. The accused were identified as Happy Singh, 20, a resident of Bhambadhi, who was working as a delivery boy for an e-commerce company, and Jaspreet Singh alias Jassi, 25, a carpenter from Mastana Sahib village in Sangrur.

"A motorcycle and mobile phone used in the crime have been recovered from the accused. Sections of the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act (UAPA) have been added to the FIR already registered in this case," the SSP said.

According to the SSP, the preliminary investigation revealed that the accused were in contact with a foreign-based handler identified as Rana Bhai. "The country where Rana Bhai is based is part of the ongoing investigation and will be disclosed later," Grewal said.

He transferred ₹1,200 and ₹1,000 in two separate transactions. The accused recorded a video of the attack to send to Rana and receive the remaining promised amount," the SSP said. **HTC**

Protests erupt in Panjab
University after scholar
electrocuted on campus

HTC & agencies

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CHANDIGARH: A PhD scholar at Panjab University's (PU) department of microbiology died of suspected electrocution on the campus on Tuesday, police said. The incident triggered protest at the university, with students demanding the vice chancellor's resignation.

According to officials, the incident took place when 28-year-old Jyoti was going to the department at the University Institute of Engineering and Technology (UIET) from girls' hostel number eight and took an unpaved pathway due to rainfall-induced waterlogging in the area. The scholar came in contact with exposed live wires and collapsed. She was rushed to the hospital where doctors declared her brought dead, they added.

Vansh Raj, a worker at PU, found the scholar, a resident of Haryana's Mahendergarh, lying in the rainwater near some electrical junction boxes. Raj said he dragged her out of the water holding a wooden stick. "Other passersby joined in soon and we rubbed her feet to revive her before an ambulance arrived," he said.

While a post-mortem examination could not be conducted on Tuesday – her family could not complete the required formalities as they reached the city late afternoon, a medical officer at Government Multi Speciality Hospital, Sector 16, said there were no visible external injuries on her body.

SSP Kanwardeep Kaur confirmed that Sector II police station have registered an FIR under the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS) for causing death by negligence.

Meanwhile, students alleged negligence by administration and demanded accountability. Several student unions locked the gates of V-C Renu Vig's office demanding her resignation, along with senior officials. They have also demanded ₹3 crore compensation for the scholar's family. Meanwhile, the family members have demanded a CBI investigation into the incident.



Research scholar Jyoti

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POSTAL SERVICE VAN
ATTACKED, 35 BAGS
BURNT IN MANIPUR

Thomas Ngangom

letters@hindustantimes.com

IMPHAL: Unknown miscreants in Manipur's Ukhrul district had blocked an Indian Postal Service mail van and burnt 35 postal bags carrying ATM cards, passports and letters at Shang-kai village, officials confirmed on Tuesday. The staff of the Indian Postal Service, Head Office, Imphal branch, staged a one-day protest on Tuesday at the office premises.

Ukhrul sub-post office postmaster, Wungreipam Rimai said, "A few unknown miscreants, who identified themselves as bandh supporters of the ongoing counter economic blockade in the state, detained the mail van at Shang-kai village, Ukhrul district along the NH-202 and burnt all the parcels forcibly."

The parcels contained ATM cards, foreign passports, letters, other parcels including educational certificates and other household items, Rimai added. The Ukhrul district post office lodged a complaint with the Litan police station, requesting a thorough investigation.

Kuki-Zo groups in Manipur have launched an indefinite counter-economic blockade on July 13 where one Assam Rifles soldier died and four others were injured.

TN minister boycotts convocation
of university over state anthem row

S Vijay Karthik

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CHENNAI: Tamil Nadu higher education minister P Viswanathan boycotted the 33rd convocation of Manonmaniam Sundaranar University in Tirunelveli on Tuesday after the Centre's directive placed the state anthem, Tamil Thaa Vazhthu, third on the programme.

Viswanathan, who is also the university's pro-chancellor, skipped the ceremony in protest while Tamil Nadu governor Rajendra Arlekar, the chief guest, presented degrees to the new graduates.

A dispute has been simmering in the state since a circular from the Centre in February instructed that Vande Mataram be played first at events presided over by the Governor and President, followed by the national anthem and then the state anthem. On May 10, the row flared when the state anthem was played third at swearing-in of C Joseph Vijay as the CM.

Vice-chancellor Professor Dr N Chandrasekar announced at the convocation that Viswanathan could not participate due to "administrative reasons". According to the V-C's announcement, Vande Mataram

was sung first, followed by the national anthem and then Tamil Thaa Vazhthu.

The higher education minister's office later posted on social media: "As a mark of protest against the V-C's announcement that Tamil Thaa Vazhthu will be sung in third place, the minister boycotted the convocation ceremony...Tamil Thaa Vazhthu must always be given its proper place and respect."

DMK MP and senior leader Kanimozhi Karunanidhi said: "For the first time in a Tamil Nadu university, the Tamil Thaa Vazhthu has been pushed to third place..."

MAN KILLS WIFE,
SENDS VIDEO TO
HER KIN; HELD

HT Correspondent

letters@hindustantimes.com

BAGALKOT: A 29-year-old man was detained in Bagalkot district of Karnataka for allegedly killing his wife, suspecting her of having an extramarital affair, police said on Tuesday. He apparently also filmed the victim's final moments.

The 23-year-old woman was found dead at the couple's house in Galagali village on Monday evening, they said.

Police registered a murder case against the deceased woman's husband based on a complaint filed by her father. He has been detained for questioning, police said.

NIA to take over
July 13 Nagaland
IED blast case probe

KOHIMA: The National Investigation Agency (NIA) has been entrusted to take over the investigation of the suspected improvised explosive device (IED) blast in Nagaland's Chumoukedima district on July 13 where one Assam Rifles soldier died and four others were injured.

Suspended trainee
IPS officer detained
by Telangana police

HYDERABAD: Telangana police on Tuesday took trainee Indian Police Service (IPS) officer M Uday Krishna Reddy into custody in connection with a sexual harassment case registered on the complaint of a fellow trainee IPS officer at the National Police Academy (NPA) in Hyderabad.

K Alagiri's daughter
gets bail in assault
case of bank manager

CHENNAI: Kayaivizhi Alagiri, the grand daughter of the late DMK patriarch M Karunanidhi and daughter of former Union minister M K Alagiri, was arrested on Tuesday for abusing and assaulting the manager of an SBI branch in Chennai, and was released on bail on the same day, police said.

CID launches probe
into missing report
of 2008 Odisha case

BHUBANESWAR: The Odisha police's Criminal Investigation Department on Tuesday registered a case and launched its probe into the disappearance of an inquiry commission's report on the killing of VHP leader Laxmananda Saraswati and subsequent communal violence in Kandhama.

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Strong safeguards in post 2014 FTAs: Govt

Rajeev Jayaswal and Smriti Kalki Ramchandran

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: India's pre-2014 free trade agreements were mostly with small and competing economies whereas India has recently signed FTAs with large and complementary economies, the government said in a presentation to members of Parliament (MPs) at the National Democratic Alliance (NDA) parliamentary party meeting on Tuesday, emphasising that all recent deals have strong safeguards for farmers as key farm sectors such as grains, dairy, poultry and spices have been fully protected.

The presentation by Union minister Piyush Goyal, highlighted FTAs as an instrument adopted by developed countries to drive trade and economic growth. "Countries such as China, USA, South Korea, Japan, Singapore, Vietnam have grown rapidly due to massive investments, large-scale manufacturing and exports," it said. HT has reviewed a copy of the presentation.

While Goyal made a presentation on FTAs, his cabinet colleague, Rajiv Ranjan Singh (Lallan Singh) made a presentation on the achievements of fisheries and aquaculture in India's Blue Economy at the meeting, also attended by Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

Rebel lawmakers of the Trinamool Congress (TMC) who have now joined the NCP were also present at the meeting.

Referring to India's FTAs signed before 2014, Goyal said they have been mostly with "small, competing and low per capita income economies" such as the ones with Asean, SAARC, Bhutan and Sri Lanka.

Although, India's FTA with 10-member bloc Association of Southeast Asian Nations (Asean) in 2009 was a big agreement, but it favoured Asean nations the most, officials said, requesting anonymity.

The Asean-India Trade in Goods Agreement (AITGA) was signed during the United Progressive Alliance (UPA) regime by then commerce minister Anand Sharma in 2009, and was operationalised in 2010. AITGA became a sore point between India and Asean due to its misuse in dumping cheaper goods from third countries, mainly China, the officials cited above said. According to them, the Union government voiced its



Prime Minister Narendra Modi, Union home minister Amit Shah and other NDA leaders during the Parliamentary Party Meeting in New Delhi on Tuesday.

concern over asymmetrical trade relationship and a review of the FTA was initiated. The government is negotiating with Asean to reverse the previous one-sided deal as India's trade deficit with the 10-member bloc surged to a whopping USD 45.20 billion by 2024-25 from a mere USD 4.58 billion in 2010-11, which is alarming, they added.

The presentation highlighted that the terms were not favourable for India as the UPA government did not consult stakeholders before signing FTAs, hence deals with Asean, South Korea and Japan were not balanced and fruitful for Indian exporters. It also added that the erstwhile government was negotiating to become part of the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership (RCEP) that would have opened up floodgates for Chinese goods in India.

At the final hours during the Asean Summit in Bangkok in November 2019, Prime Minister Narendra Modi averted India's entry into RCEP, saying he did not find it good for the country.

According to the presentation, India's pre-2014 FTAs covered a combined GDP of USD 10 trillion as compared to nine FTAs New Delhi has signed post 2014, which covers economies having combined GDP of USD 60 trillion.

Singh said the seafood export doubled from ₹30,213 crore in 2013-14 to ₹62,408 crore in 2024-25, an increase by 107%.

In April 2025, the US imposed tariff to the extent of 58% and was the largest market accounting for 36% of the total seafood exports. The fallout of imposed tariffs was a matter of great concern for fish farmers, exporters, state governments and other stakeholders but the Union government reached out to all the stakeholders to understand

ground challenges and issues, the presentation said.

New Delhi signed the India-Mauritius Comprehensive Economic Cooperation and Partnership Agreement (CECPA) on February 22, 2021, which was operationalised on April 1, 2021. In the next year, the government signed two separate FTAs with important economies — one with the United Arab Emirates (UAE) on February 18, 2022 and the other with Australia on April 2, 2022. They were operationalised on May 1 and December 29, respectively, of the same year.

On March 10, 2024, India signed an FTA with the European Free Trade Association (EFTA), a bloc of four developed European nations — Iceland, Liechtenstein, Norway and Switzerland — where EFTA nations committed USD 100 billion investments in India over 15 years. The India-EFTA Trade and Economic Partnership Agreement (TEPA) was operationalised on October 1, 2025. Similar FTAs were signed with Oman and the UK on December 18 and July 24, 2025, respectively.

The India's FTA with New Zealand has been signed on April 27, 2026, and currently under ratification process.

India and 27-member European Union on January 27, 2026, concluded negotiating the mother of all FTAs, which is expected to be signed by the end of this year. Besides that, India and the United States on February 7, 2026, jointly announced a framework to conclude an interim bilateral trade agreement (BITA) at the earliest.

At the last week's parliamentary party meeting, the Prime Minister had instructed the lawmakers to reach out to the youth that had taken to the streets in protest over irregularities in the conduct of examinations.

[DRAFT BILL LIKELY THIS PARL SESSION]

Define digital arrest as a standalone offence: SC

Abraham Thomas

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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Tuesday said that digital arrest frauds require to be defined as a standalone offence with harsh punishment and a provision to attach assets of accused after the Centre said that work is underway to come out with a draft bill covering digital arrest cases preferably to be presented in the present session of Parliament.

The suggestion by the court came in a suo motu petition on the victims of digital arrest fraud where it is examining steps being taken by an inter-departmental committee (IDC) of the Centre supervising action against such cyber frauds on multiple fronts.

A bench headed by Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant said, "We need to formally define digital arrest. Though it is a clear case of extortion and involves robbery and some element of dacoity as well, we need

to define it as a standalone offence with severe penal consequences."

Noting the occurrence of such frauds being reported throughout the country, the bench, also comprising justices Joymalaya Bagchi and V Mohana, said, "This must be accompanied with a provision that where, prima facie, there is a finding of involvement of a person, all his movable and immovable assets must be frozen."

Solicitor general Tushar Mehta, appearing for the Centre, informed the bench, "On the statutory changes to be made, I must inform the court that there is a draft Bill coming up possibly in this Parliament session on digital arrest fraud."

The bench said that the Centre may also be required to have a look at the Information Technology Act, 2000, in the age of deepfakes and digital arrest cases. "Changes may be required to offences such as hacking by impersonation (section 66D) in such cases. Today, there are sev-



SC posted the matter for further hearing on Wednesday.

eral technological tools for cheating and impersonation that require you to have a relook."

It said that the coming times may require law to adapt to technological advancements where a robot may be commissioned for a crime and a drone may be accused of committing an act of trespass. "We know that you have tools to fight with. We want you to chisel your tools. Our difficulty is that under Article 142 of the Constitution (court's extraordinary power to pass any order to do complete justice), we cannot define a crime."

The bench posted the matter for further hearing on Wednesday.

day as it was presented with two orders compiled by the Attorney General K Venkataramani and senior advocate NS Nappinal, assisting the court as amicus curiae. Venkataramani's note gave a brief of steps taken so far by the IDC and sought certain orders to be passed for strengthening the mechanism to prevent digital arrest frauds from taking place.

While high-value digital arrest cases are automatically marked to CBI, the remaining complaints are handled by the respective state police forces.

At the same time, Nappinal claimed that the digital arrest cases continue unabated as she highlighted the need for a "kill switch" by which that platforms such as WhatsApp can automatically terminate a video call extending beyond 6 to 12 hours or even generate a pop-up to the user indicating the call to be suspect. In her interaction with victims, she said that victims need an expedited "victim compensation framework" as their cases

either remain pending in consumer courts or before an adjudicating officer under the IT Act. The bench asked Venkataramani on the possibility of having a common authority to deal with digital arrest complaints. With the Centre proposing to bring a law, the bench said, "Why don't you have a structured organisation to look into all this. It could be some kind of a body having statutory or legislative force behind it." Presently, the bench noted that the matter is being examined separately at various fronts - RBI for banks, Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY) for social media intermediaries and Ministry of Home Affairs for law enforcement agencies.

The court said it will pass further orders in the matter as IDC recommended immediate operationalisation of protocols and measures proposed by it in the past for effective and smooth coordination between various stakeholders in providing relief to victims of digital arrest fraud.

5 OF FAMILY KILLED AFTER CAR FALLS INTO GORGE IN H.P

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DHARAMSHALA: Five people of a family were killed after the car they were travelling in plunged into a deep gorge in Himachal Pradesh's Chamba district, officials said on Tuesday.

The mishap occurred on Bhamour-Pathankot National Highway in the wee hours on Tuesday at Lahar near Banikhet in Chamba when the car went out of control and fell into the gorge. All five occupants of the vehicle, who belonged to the same family, were killed in the crash, police said. The victims included a three-month-old infant.

Police said the family was returning home to the Dharwala area of Chamba from Chandigarh when the accident occurred, adding that the exact cause of the accident is yet to be ascertained. An investigation has been initiated to determine the circumstances leading to the crash.

Meanwhile, chief minister Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu expressed grief over the accident. He directed the district administration to provide all possible assistance to the bereaved family members.

Assam flood toll rises to 75; rains wreak havoc in Himalayan states

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NEW DELHI: Seven more deaths have been reported on Tuesday from the flood-affected districts in Assam, raising the toll to 75. Chief minister Himanta Biswa Sarma has relaxed the norms for providing an ex-gratia to families of those dead or missing in floods this year, while announcing an additional ₹5 lakh compensation over and above ₹4 lakh payment to families of the deceased.

According to a report for Assam State Disaster Management Authority (ASDMA), all seven deaths were reported from Sibsagar, the worst affected district in this month's flooding.

"We will leave no stone unturned to support our people and help them rebuild their lives," he said, while making a slew of relief announcements in the wake of the natural calamity. Marshes and certificates of important examinations lost due to floods would be provided free of cost, the CM added. He also announced that a sum of ₹15,000 would be provided as immediate relief to around 100,000 families in order to help them procure



A portion of the newly constructed bridge collapsed on the Dehradun-Paonta Sahib Highway due to heavy rainfall.

essential items.

Meanwhile, parts of northern India were also severely hit by rain on Tuesday, triggering landslides and flash floods in the Himalayan states. The India Meteorological Department (IMD) has forecast above-normal rainfall over northwest and central India in the next four to five days.

In Himachal, moderate to heavy rains caused landslides in Chamba district, where about a dozen vehicles and many houses were buried in debris. However,

no loss of life has been reported so far. The Met office said there was a moderate flash-flood threat in a few watersheds and neighbourhoods in seven out of 12 districts in the state.

In Uttarakhand, the Char Dham Yatra routes have been blocked at several locations due to landslides. Officials have suspended the yatra for two days till today due to a heavy rain alert.

Rains also lashed many places in Punjab and Haryana, bringing relief from the ongoing hot weather in the two states.

RELEASE 3.5K CUSECS CAUVERY WATER TO T.N. DAILY FOR 15 DAYS, PANEL TELLS K'TAKA

NEW DELHI: The Cauvery Water Regulation Committee (CWRC) has recommended that Karnataka release 3,500 cusecs of water per day to Tamil Nadu for the next 15 days. The committee has also recommended releasing a total of 4 tmcft of water.

Following the meeting in New Delhi, Karnataka Water Resources Minister Ramalinga Reddy responded to the directive. "We are facing a water shortage. I will discuss with the CM and take a decision."

"There has been no rain here. We need drinking water for the entire year," he added.

On whether Karnataka would challenge the recommendation, Reddy said, "We will discuss and decide on going on appeal to the Cauvery Water Management Authority." The state government is expected to take a final call after discussions with chief minister DK Shivakumar.

Meanwhile, sporadic protests broke out in Mysuru and Mandya districts over the development. Speaking to news agency PTL, Kannada activist Vatal Nagaraj told reporters that releasing water to Tamil Nadu will amount to betrayal at a time when the state is reeling under acute drought. mtc

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FIRST VOICE. LAST WORD.

SC-PROTEST VIOLENCE

The protection, the court clarified, would not extend to antisocial elements or persons with criminal antecedents.

The order came on a batch of petitions alleging excessive force during student protests, including the July 20 march to Parliament in Delhi and subsequent stunts in several states.

The proceedings saw the bench repeatedly underscore that peaceful protests enjoy constitutional protection, even as it acknowledged that violence by either side deserved equal scrutiny.

"It was completely a peaceful protest by students raising demands. Such a protest is permissible and protected under the Constitution," observed the CJ, while cautioning that peaceful demonstrations often witness the entry of "uninvited guests with agendas" who end up becoming "co-hosts".

"Why should there not be an independent probe into all of this?" the bench asked. Appearing for petitioner Shalish Mani Tripathi, senior advocate Gopal Santharanyan catalogued allegations ranging from pellet gun injuries causing permanent loss of eyesight to the use of electric batons, assault on women protesters, attacks on journalists and violence by police personnel allegedly dressed in civilian clothes. His submissions were followed by senior counsel AM Singhvi, Shyam Divan, Shob Alam, Shadan Farasat and advocates Prashant Bhushan and Vrinda Grover, representing other petitioners and applicants in the matter.

The bench noted the "use of pellet guns, electric batons and lathi resulting in life-threatening injuries" and allegations regarding assaults on media personnel and women protesters required serious examination. "There are just some instances. Once the protocol is in place, whoever has taken law into their own hands, committed atrocities against innocent people, law should deal with them. For that, a fair and impartial probe has to take place. A probe is meaningless if it does not fasten accountability. The court also flagged what it described as the need to revisit the legal framework governing police response to demonstrations." The previous judgments, starting with Anita Thakur in 2020, with the passage of time may require some modifications and updates", observed the bench, adding that the court

intended to "collate all these principles" and strengthen earlier directions governing crowd-control measures, including the use of tear gas and other force.

Signalling that the exercise could culminate in fresh nationwide norms, the bench remarked that there may be a need for a standing mechanism capable of responding immediately whenever large-scale protests arise. "Perhaps, we need to have a mechanism so that as and when certain emergency situations arise, that mechanism can be immediately brought into force," it added.

At one stage, the court observed that protective gear for police personnel was more important than offensive equipment, remarking that officers should, wherever possible, allow time before resorting to serious crowd-control measures such as tear gas.

The hearing also brought before the court allegations from Bihar, where several claimed AK-47 rifles were used during protests and minors had remained in detention beyond the permissible period. Farasat alleged that photographs of juvenile protesters was published in newspapers.

The bench responded by observing that it was contemplating a high-powered investigating committee capable of examining incidents extending beyond Delhi.

Solicitor general Tushar Mehta, appearing for the Centre and Delhi Police, stated that the government had no objection to an independent probe, while disputing allegations of excessive force.

He submitted that if students had suffered unlawfully, "the perpetrators have to be brought to book", but emphasised that over 200 police personnel had also suffered injuries and that the morale of the police force could not be undermined. Mehta suggested that antisocial elements may have infiltrated the demonstrations, adding that he did not believe students were responsible for violence.

"There is always a danger of discrediting a peaceful movement," remarked the court, stressing that accountability could emerge only through a "scientific and evidence-based probe". The matter will be heard on August 3, when the Centre and the states are expected to file their responses before the court considers the constitution of the independent investigative mechanism and the broader issue of nationwide protest-management guidelines.

DELHI AID FOR WOMEN

entire ₹2,500 by way of an RD or FD, with the government describing it as a mechanism to encourage long-term savings. Under both options, beneficiaries will not be able to withdraw cash.

According to the approved guidelines, beneficiaries will also be encouraged to ensure school enrolment of children, creation of APAR and ABHA IDs, timely immunisation, and registration on the POSHAN Tracker.

The scheme also seeks to promote participation in campaigns such as Ek Ped Mai Ke Naam, Swachh Bharat Mission, and others against single-use plastic, while encouraging women to join self-help groups and skill development programmes.

The government said applications will be processed entirely online through the Delhi Lakshmi Yojana portal.

BCCI CONTRACTS Three names being discussed, it is understood that former India women's coach Ryan Ten Doeschate's two-year contract with Indian men's team ended on June 10. Fielding coach T Dilip, who was given a one-year extension after his original term ended, also has his contract ending on June 8. BCCI secretary Saikia told PTI in an exclusive interaction.

"The BCCI continued with the duo till the end of India's tour of United Kingdom. However, the BCCI is not giving them any extension. There is no question of accepting resignation as the contract has ended," the secretary cleared the air. It must be mentioned that Ten Doeschate intended to leave as when he was brought on board on Gambhir's insistence, he was promised fielding coach's job but was given no specific role in last two years.

In case of Dilip, his extension for one year before the 2025 Test series in England was on insistence of a senior superstar but no one was happy with his performance. "We are currently in talks with two to three names and expect to finalise the details within a day or two. India will have a new fielding coach for tour of Sri Lanka," Saikia said. However, Assam's Ghosh, who has been in the system since the time of Rahul Dravid at the NCA, is the favourite right now.

The government also finalised the manner in which the monthly assistance can be received. Beneficiaries will have two options. Under the first, ₹1,500 will be deposited every month in a recurring deposit or fixed deposit account while the remaining ₹1,000 will be transferred to a Central Bank Digital Currency (CBDC) digital rupee wallet. Spending through the digital wallet will be restricted to government-approved goods and services under a prescribed negative list.

The negative list of a wallet usually includes numbers that are associated with frauds or scams (so payments cannot be made to such numbers that are on the negative list).

The second option allows beneficiaries to receive the

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Top Maoist Besra, carrying bounty of over ₹1 cr, arrested

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NEW DELHI: Misir Besra, the last remaining Central Committee (CC) and Politburo member of the CPI (Maoist), was arrested in Jharkhand's Dhanbad district on Tuesday, officials from the CRPF and Jharkhand Police said. Carrying a reward of more than ₹1 crore on information leading to his arrest, Besra was caught in the Tundi-Mandiya forest area near the Dhanbad-Giridih border while allegedly trying to flee a security operation, they said.

Two of his associates, Gaurav Hasdia and Mochu, were also arrested.

With Besra's arrest, no active Central Committee member of the banned CPI (Maoist) remains at large, officials said. At its peak, the outfit had more than 40 Central Committee members. Over the years, security forces have arrested, killed or secured the surrender of the remaining 21



Misir Besra

active CC members. Besra had been among the few senior leaders who consistently refused to surrender.

"He was trapped in the jungle area on the foothills of the Parasnath temple. At around 9 pm, he was trying to flee the jungle due to the massive deployment of forces and yesterday's surrender of his key associates. He has been caught alive after more than two decades," an official requesting anonymity said. Besra's son, Siddharth Besra, said he had not yet been formally informed of the arrest. Security

agencies had repeatedly approached the family to persuade the Maoist leader to surrender. "Just 15 days ago, the police had come and asked me to write another letter requesting him to surrender. I have not seen him in 20 years but am glad that the forces have caught him alive," Siddharth said.

Officials said Besra's continued presence in the Saranda forests of West Singhbhum district was one of the reasons the Union government continued to classify the district as a "district of concern" for Left-Wing Extremism. Most other districts that were once major Maoist strongholds, including Bastar in Chhattisgarh, have been removed from the list following a series of surrenders and encounters involving senior Maoist leaders.

With Besra's arrest, officials said the Union home ministry is likely to review West Singhbhum's status as a district of concern.

Man held for posing as officer, raping minors

JODHPUR: A 47-year-old man was arrested in Jodhpur for allegedly befriending multiple minors by posing as an IAS officer and then raping them, police said on Tuesday. The accused was identified as Umaram Bishnoi. Police said the case came to light through a complaint submitted on Sunday by a survivor, who alleged that the accused reached out to her in 2024 and offered to help improve her board exam scores.

Farmers march towards Bhopal, seek 100% moong procurement

BHOPAL: Around 2,000 farmers from Harda and Narmadapuram reached Bhopal on Tuesday, demanding 100% government procurement of moong (green gram) and improvements in the online fertiliser distribution system. Currently, the state procures 1.2 quintals per acre, but farmers argue that actual production ranges between 5-6 quintals per acre. They insist that the government must procure the entire crop. Nineteen farmer organisations under the banner of the Samyukt Kisan Morcha are participating in the protest.

Woman killed as elderly couple attacked in Kota

KOTA: A couple was attacked in their sleep at their home in a village in Kota on Tuesday, murdering the 70-year-old wife and critically injuring the husband, with police saying they are yet to establish the reason behind the home invasion as no valuables were found to be missing.

6 yrs since NEP 2020 rollout: What worked, what remains unfulfilled

Sanjay Maurya

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NEW DELHI: Six years after the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020 was approved by the Union Cabinet on July 29, 2020, India's most ambitious education reform in over three decades has delivered mixed results.

The policy, which replaced the 1986 education policy, sought to transform education from pre-primary to higher education through curriculum reforms, flexible learning pathways, skill development and digital governance. While several changes have reached classrooms and campuses, many key reforms remain unfulfilled.

The most visible progress has come in school education. The decades-old 10+2 structure has been replaced by the 5+3+3+4 model, while the National Curriculum Framework for School Education (NCF-SE), released in 2023, has guided new NCERT textbooks for Classes 1 to 9. The books for

PUBLIC SPENDING ON EDUCATION IS STILL AROUND 4.1% OF GDP. WELL SHORT OF NEP'S 6% TARGET

Classes 10 to 12 are expected next. Early childhood education has also been formally integrated into the school system through NCERT's Jaadui Pitara learning kits and a national ECCE (Early Childhood Care and Education) curriculum.

NIPUN Bharat has institutionalised foundational literacy assessments and teacher training. The latest PARAKH's holistic progress cards are yet to be widely adopted. The shift to four-year undergraduate programmes and teacher education reforms under ITEP remain uneven across states and institutions. The proposed replacement of the University Grants Commission (UGC), AICTE and NCTE with a single higher education regulator has been repeatedly delayed. The three-language formula continues to face political resistance, particularly from Tamil Nadu.

"Six years into NEP, its ideas have begun taking root in classrooms. The focus has shifted towards conceptual learning. The next phase must invest in teacher capacity and assessments that reward understanding over rote learning," said Manish Malhotra, director-principal of Satya School, Gurugram.

Several reforms, however, remain a work in progress. CBE has introduced twice-a-year Class 10 board examinations from 2026, while PARAKH's holistic progress cards are yet to be widely adopted.

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Manipur needs honest reckoning

The Centre and the state must redouble efforts to bring everyone to the table and re-establish the primacy of law

It is clear by now that the crisis in Manipur is not one that can be resolved with piecemeal solutions or patchwork government initiatives, given that inter-community hostilities have engulfed every group in the north-eastern state. It is a sorry commentary on the administration's performance that the embers of violence continue to smoulder three years after clashes first broke out.

This newspaper reported on Tuesday that Kuki-Zo groups launched an indefinite counter-economic blockade on the highway connecting the state with neighbouring Nagaland. This came in response to an economic blockade by Naga and Meitei groups protesting against the killings of six Naga hostages last month. The decision was taken and implemented by Kuki-Zo civil society organisations, showing that the government was effectively rendered helpless. Naga and Kuki-Zo tensions escalated in May after twin ambushes left four people dead. On the same day, Kuki-Zo and Naga groups captured 48 civilians (20 Nagas and 28 Kuki-Zo). On May 15, 14 captives each from the two communities were released. The remaining 14 Kuki-Zo hostages were freed unharmed on June 9. The mutilated bodies of six Nagas were found the next day, ratcheting up tensions and triggering the blockades.

There are two clear points of worry. One is that the circle of the violence appears to be widening — hostilities that first began between the Kukis and Meiteis in 2023 (at the time, the Nagas were considered a neutral party) are now a frontal battle between the Kukis and the Nagas. This comes against the backdrop of mounting pending litigation connected to the clashes and the fact that many people continue to live in transit camps, unable to return home.

The second is the uncertain grip of the state government. In these three years, Manipur has seen every form of government, including months of President's Rule. A securitised approach focussed on pumping more forces into the state has yielded little result. When the new government took over in February, there was hope of a new beginning given that representatives from all three major communities took part. The new government can claim that it has staunchened violence to an extent. But the state is still balkanised on community lines, supply lines and highways are cut off, and tensions run high. Both the Centre and the state need to redouble efforts to bring everyone to the table and re-establish the primacy of law. An honest reckoning with the faultlines, sacrificing short-term political gains for long-term national goals, and transparent discussions on the future of Manipur are required.

When maturity took a day off on Monday

A resignation, especially one aspiring to a higher morality, is meant to be a sombre affair. Which is why it isn't clear what the BJP lawmakers cheering and celebrating the former education minister (for his resignation) in Parliament on Monday were hoping to achieve. Sure, it was political, an expression of members of a political unit not used to setbacks that this — the minister's resignation — was no defeat. Still, all they served to do was to erode the moral high ground the minister and the government had sought to take with his resignation. And they presented just the kind of optics the government would have liked to avoid.

But on Monday, it wasn't these lawmakers — fortunately a minority — alone who were guilty of bad optics. A video that was circulated widely showed some worthies of the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) loudly celebrating the end of their struggle and the resignation of the minister — an event that should have been marked with gravitas and quiet contemplation given what many students across the country went through during the protest.

Still, both the cheering lawmakers and the dancing protesters were outdone by the federal investigation agency. Two days after the end of a weeks-long protest sparked by paper leaks, and soon after the Prime Minister promised quick and tough action against anyone involved in paper leaks, the agency's lawyer deemed it fit to skip the first hearing of a fast-track court hearing a paper leak case. It's the kind of thing that is so funny that it isn't.

Sincerity, maturity, and intent — all took a day off on Monday. The more things change...

OPTION Middle India bigger, but not richer individually

Ten years of tax return data shows middle India's headcount has jumped over seven times, but within that band, the average salary has barely moved

If you felt that your salary has been stagnating over the past few years, there is now data from the income tax filings that turns the feeling into a fact. Middle India in the tax-included formal sector has expanded, but the average person within this band has barely seen salaries rise for the decade ending 2022-23. Of course, those moving up the income bands have done better, but the average person in this band has not gained much. Also, depending on the inequality narratives, the rich, on an average, have not got richer in terms of salary income. But the lower income cohort has been the biggest average salary-gainer over the decade.

The most striking story evident from the Income Tax Return Statistics for FY13 and FY23 released by the income tax department is one of opportunity between the world's two largest economies. I examine the salary tax filing of individuals. While nominal (real plus inflation) gross domestic product (GDP) grew at around 10.5% a year over the decade, the total salary growth for all individuals has been an impressive 16% a year. But the average salary of all individual income-tax

filers grew by only about 6.5% a year over the decade ending FY23.

Who is growing? The middle class. If we define the middle class as the section that has salary incomes between ₹10 and ₹50 lakh a year, this cohort has substantially increased its share of salary income over the decade. From just over a quarter in FY13, it now earns almost half of all salary income earned in FY23. A decade ago, salary incomes less than ₹10 lakh had a two-thirds share of total income — this has changed dramatically in just 10 years.

A short note on how tax payers' income is split. It is divided into five heads — salary, income from house property, income from business, capital gain, and other income. I am looking at three income cohorts for individuals (not firms or Hindu Undivided Family or any other tax-filing category) — those with less than ₹10 lakh income a year, between ₹10 lakh and ₹50 lakh, and above ₹50 lakh.

(I have removed the zero tax-payers for the ₹10 lakh and below slab as it was reducing the average salary needlessly.)

Middle India is expanding. The number of tax filers in this cohort rose seven times over the decade, the fastest among the three cohorts of salary income. But, it is not earning more per person on an average. Average salaries grew from ₹16.86 lakh in FY13 to ₹17.33 lakh in FY23 — a less than 3% growth over the decade and an average annual rate of

growth of less than 0.3% a year. The growth is in the pie, rather than the size of the slice. The impact of inflation and taxes blunts this growth in real terms, making purchasing power suffer.

What could cause this huge jump in the middle class? Possibly an upward mobility of the lower salary cohort and a rise in the number of people with formal-sector salaries jobs. So, both better jobs and formalisation of informal jobs are the most likely reasons for this growth. While

this is good news for many reasons — as a growing middle class is the backbone for long-term economic growth of a nation — the bad news is that though India is formalising the bargaining power of labour remained weak despite rapid formalisation. This is a sign of a labour-surplus economy; the pressure on wages for middle India is now showing up in the tax data.

Have the rich got richer? The answer is no, despite what the anecdotal tales and outliers will project. Their average salaries dropped 10% over the decade, while the total salary income grew by 20% a year. This might sound difficult to digest, but here is what happened. The total number of tax filers returns in this band went up by almost seven times, while the total salary income went up by just over six times. Then, did the rich do better on income from house property and profits from assets? Again, no. While the pie grew larger, the average number is actually lower.



Monika Halan

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Stronger India-Europe ties, courtesy China, US, & Russia

Amid global turbulence, the year 2026 may go down as a banner year for India-EU relations. Decades of frustration and finger-pointing have suddenly given way to unprecedented opportunities between the world's two largest democratic political entities. The conclusion in January of an India-EU free trade agreement (FTA), expected to be signed later this year, is an important milestone, one that might have taken a decade longer under different structural or political conditions.

But also important is the Security and Defence Partnership (SDP), coming just as Europe has begun to re-militarise and develop significant autonomous defence industrial capabilities. The latest development announced during the third EU-India Trade and Technology Council (TTC) meeting in formal negotiations toward India's association with the €93.5-billion Horizon Europe research and innovation programme.

These three agreements, once concluded, will create the enabling conditions for India to truly leverage a comprehensive partnership with Europe for the first time since independence. But the real test will be leveraging these conditions for benefits in terms of trade, supply chains, technological cooperation, scientific research, education, energy cooperation, and defence industrial collaboration begins now.

India-Europe relations in the post-Cold War period were long defined more by misalignment than strategic convergence. In the 1990s and even after the Lisbon Treaty, India approached the EU mostly as a trade bloc, notwithstanding important bilateral relations with the UK, France, and Germany. New Delhi was often frustrated by a lack of coordination among European capitals and limited security and people-to-people cooperation.

For its part, Europe's singular focus on the transatlantic alliance with the US, its concerns about Russia and its partnerships, and the seduction of China's large market contributed to India's relative marginalisation. For European business, legislators, and academics, India remained a low priority.

Three main factors have altered these perceptions significantly.

One, the Covid-19 pandemic, Beijing's wolf warriorism, and China's economic overcapacity have motivated both India and Europe to de-risk from China's over-concentration of supply chains.

Two, Russia's war in Ukraine has not just heightened threat perceptions in Europe but has disrupted potential defence and strategic supplies to India, requiring new defence industrial partnerships.

Three, both Europe and India have been the object of US tariffs and sharp political disagreements during Donald Trump's second

and presidency. Taken together, the consolidation of a wide-ranging India-Europe partnership is a natural outgrowth.

Other factors have helped. Europe and India align more on issues such as Artificial Intelligence (AI) and technology regulation or on clean energy investments than either currently does with the US or China. The promise of building resilience and connectivity via West Asia — in the form of the India-Middle East-Europe Corridor (IMEC) — is today a more appealing prospect for India and Europe than a Belt and Road Initiative across Eurasia, even taking into account continuing conflicts in Gaza and Iran.

A series of bilateral mobility agreements between India and individual European countries have significantly increased the number of Indian students and temporary workers in continental Europe, contributing to stronger people-to-people ties. And India has acknowledged these developments by welcoming its diplomatic footprint in Europe, opening up new consulates and embassies in places such as Belfast and Barcelona, Latvia and Ljubljana.

The renewed push for cooperation between India and the EU can, in large part, be credited to top-down directives from Prime Minister (PM) Narendra Modi and Euro-

pean Commission President Ursula von der Leyen. The EU-India Summit hosted by then Portuguese PM (and current European Council President) Antonio Costa during the Covid-19 pandemic in 2021 helped put India on the map of Europe's national leaders. But India's hosting the entire European College of Commissioners in February 2025 deeply impressed the leadership and senior bureaucracy in Brussels and indicated New Delhi's seriousness in taking the partnership forward. In the run-up to this year's Republic Day — at which the FTA and SDP were finalised — complications arose, but were surmounted with both flexibility and top-down intent. A compromise was reached on Europe's carbon border adjustment mechanism (CBAM), some European conditionalities were also made non-binding on India, and Indian concerns about agricultural controls (OCOs) were also addressed. By the end of 2026, should the three major enabling agreements be fully concluded, the TTC will remain a centralised decision-making mechanism to deliver on joint outcomes and projects.

While these formal structures take shape over the next year, other institutions will need to catch up. At present, the state of contemporary India in Europe and that of contemporary Europe in India are both to be found wanting. There are few well-informed interpreters of policy at think tanks and non-governmental institutions. Indian business groups and trade bodies are insufficiently represented in Brussels, where regulations with significant implications for India are often decided. European corporate entities often lack a basic understanding of India's economic and trade policies and business environment. As official EU-India relations have surged ahead over the past year, the non-governmental sector will quickly need to catch up.

Dhruva Jaishankar is executive director of ORF America in Washington DC. The views expressed are personal



Efforts to formalise and widen the tax net are working. But, unless average wages go up for individuals, consumption will begin to drag. HT ARCHIVE

The big surprise is the growth of average income in the bottom cohort, despite some recent inequality studies painting a darker picture. The tax return data tell a more nuanced story. Those with salary income up to ₹10 lakh a year have actually seen the highest growth in average income when compared to the middle class and the rich. Average salaries grew 32% for this cohort over the decade, taking average salary up from ₹3.87 lakh to ₹5.10 lakh — a growth rate of almost 3% a year.

But, how can the overall salary average be higher than all the three cohorts? The overall average rose because millions of taxpayers moved into higher salary bands. But once we compare taxpayers within the same salary band, average salaries were almost flat.

The full story is this: The pie is expanding, the country is creating more formal sector jobs, and more people are coming into the tax net. None of the three cohorts experienced average salary growth commensurate with the rapid expansion in total salary income. Nearly all of the increase came from more taxpayers entering the system rather than existing taxpayers earning substantially more

within the band. For policymakers, it is clear that efforts to formalise and widen the tax net are working; this must continue to gather in more. But equally, unless average wages go up for individuals, consumption will begin to drag. And that usually goes into a downward loop, with lower production, layoffs and even lower consumption. Right now the sheer volume is keeping it going, but at some point the wage upgrade will need to kick in for sustained growth.

What can middle India do? Just skill up. The potential for low-hanging productivity gains is far higher in India, than say a US. Your individual real wage growth is in your hands and most often the way is zig-zag — usually by switching jobs. Increments in the same place of work, for some reason, are always difficult. Update your resume at least every quarter and any company that doesn't want to add, take it as a red flag. Barring few, there is no "family" firm. It is a contract. Get a better job. Move.

Monika Halan is the best-selling author of the Let's Talk series of books on money. The views expressed are personal

FIONA FRAZER | REPRESENTATIVE, UNOCHCR



International humanitarian law provides special protections for medical personnel and humanitarian workers... Attacks against them... are prohibited

On the killing of civilians in Pakistan-Afghanistan conflict

The Modi-Takaichi era dawns in India-Japan ties

Earlier this month, Japanese Prime Minister (PM) Narendra Modi paid his first official visit to Japan, after assuming office last October. The outcomes of this visit can be captured through two keywords: "strategic convergence" and "younger sister". The leaders' joint statement characterised the relationship between the two nations as a "partnership of strategic convergence and trust for shared growth, prosperity and mutual benefit". Building on the decade-long progress made under "special strategic and global partnership", both sides concurred on advancing their strategically convergent partnership. Strategic convergence signifies that the relationship has evolved beyond merely sharing strategic interests.

The other keyword is "younger sister". During this visit, the two leaders concurred to call each other "elder brother" and "younger sister". At the joint press statement's opening, PM Narendra Modi warmly called PM Takaichi his "chhoti behen" (younger sister), a memorable moment to which she responded in kind. The two leaders cultivating such a close relationship is one of the greatest achievements of this visit.

Japan's importance to India rests on three pillars for "Viksit Bharat": a reliable partner for economic development, a strategic partner for security interests, and a trusted partner rooted in cultural bonds.

With the opening of the Takaichi-Modi era, I would like to place priority on five key areas.

First, advancing policy coordination across the Indo-Pacific region. The two leaders reiterated the synergy between India's MAHATAGAR and Japan's updated Free and Open Indo-Pacific (FOIP). PM Takaichi emphasised that each country must have resilience and capabilities to have freedom to decide for themselves and become stronger and more prosperous together. Alligning perspectives and understanding at all levels and advancing third-country cooperation — such as the trilateral Track 15 policy dialogue with the Philippines — remain crucial. Japan and India may explore more trilateral/minilateral dialogue with third countries in the Indo-Pacific. The two leaders underscored the importance of Quad collaboration and reaffirmed their commitment to cooperating towards an early convening of the next Quad leaders' summit.

Second, deepening security and defence cooperation, especially in maritime security. The two countries announced their commitment to advancing defence equipment and technology cooperation under the Make in India initiative and promoting collaboration in areas including naval maintenance, repair, and overhaul. An agreement in principle has

also been reached on the technical collaboration regarding the Unified Complex Radio Antenna (UNICORN). Japan and India will steadily advance cooperation in these areas, including through the 2+2 foreign and defence ministerial meeting by the end of this year.

Third, expanding practical cooperation on economic security. The two leaders announced the Joint Declaration on Economic Security Cooperation. As India's first such declaration with any country, it demonstrates a deep bilateral cooperation. The private sector's strong interest is driving concrete collaboration across five key areas — semiconductors, critical minerals, ICT, clean energy, and pharmaceuticals. We will continue to promote concrete projects in areas such as semiconductors, AI, and clean energy. Alongside government-to-government and business-to-business dialogues, a new Track 15 Dialogue will further institutionalise our economic security cooperation.

Fourth, promoting concrete industrial and innovation initiatives. We are steadily progressing toward the J-Indian lion-yuan Japan investment in India targeted, with 2 trillion yen already announced since 2025. Attended by both PMs, the Japan-India Joint Economic Forum drew 700 business leaders from approximately 200 Japanese and 80 Indian companies, demonstrating strong business interest from both sides. The two leaders have also shared the view to accelerate private-sector-led cooperation. It is important to enhance mobility and acknowledged the importance of cooperation in the shipping sector. The Mumbai-Ahmedabad High-Speed Rail project, reaffirmed by both leaders as a flagship project, will steadily advance through bilateral cooperation between Japan and India, and both sides will continue to work closely together. We aim to leverage the proposed Japan-India Business Week, led by the PMs' Office, to drive further investments through business environment improvements and actively supporting corporate matchmaking.

Fifth, translating the partnership of trust into concrete actions through the 75th anniversary of Japan-India diplomatic relations in 2027. To commemorate next year's milestone anniversary, we will launch key initiatives, including the late-April Japan-India Week, pop culture, intellectual and youth exchanges, and sports. Focusing on these five areas, we will further enhance the strategic convergence between Japan and India in the Takaichi-Modi era. Looking ahead, PM Modi and PM Takaichi next year, we remain fully committed to deepening the Japan-India partnership.

Ono Keiichi is Japan's ambassador to India. The views expressed are personal

WORLD



Israel's Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu (left) met with US President Donald Trump in the Oval Office of the White House in Washington DC, on Tuesday. Netanyahu visited the White House for his first in-person talks with Trump since the Iran war began on February 28, as the leaders sought to patch over public disagreements on the conflict. AFP

Iran proposal seeks greater strait control

Reuters
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DUBAI: Iran has proposed to Oman a temporary arrangement to reopen the Strait of Hormuz under which one direction of traffic would pass through Iranian waters and part of the opposite route would also be in Iranian waters, Deputy Foreign Minister Kazem Gharibabadi told state television on Tuesday.

Gharibabadi said Tehran rejected an Omani proposal for an equal division of transit routes between the two countries, saying such a plan did not address Tehran's security concerns until long-term regional stability is achieved.

He said the Strait of Hormuz would remain closed if Muscat rejected Iran's proposal, adding that Tehran had never recognised the southern route along Oman's coast.

Gharibabadi also said Tehran had made it clear to Muscat that it no longer recognised the Traffic Separation Scheme (TSS),

TANKERS HEAD TO EGYPT AS HOUTHIS THREAT UPENDS RED SEA TRADE

RIYADH: Empty supertankers are heading to Egypt's Mediterranean port of Sidi Kerir to collect Saudi crude as observable traffic at the kingdom's key Red Sea export hub dwindles following threats from Houthi militants.

At least eight very large crude carriers are signalling Sidi Kerir and are set to arrive in the coming weeks through to mid-August, ship-tracking data shows. **BLOOMBERG**

arguing that this pathway roughly in the middle of the waterway lies mostly within Omani waters and runs contrary to Iran's need to monitor transiting vessels after being attacked by the US and Israel in late February.

The TSS, adopted by the International Maritime Organization, is currently unusable due to the risk of mines and has been replaced with Iran's northern route and Oman's southern route.

"This is for national security and not bullying because when the TSS was for 60 years in Omani waters, we didn't say anything," Gharibabadi said.

The Iranian diplomat also warned that Tehran would not allow any third country, even if invited by Oman, to de-mine the Strait of Hormuz.

Gulf Cooperation Council foreign ministers met via video call on Tuesday to discuss the latest developments in the conflict, including ways to intensify cooperation on issues related to freedom and safety of vessels through the waterway, a statement from the Qatari Foreign Ministry said.

Late on Tuesday, the Houthis said they had fired ballistic missiles at a Saudi oil tanker, which they said was forced to turn back. Iran has said it would hold fire as long as Washington does.

But drone attacks were reported in Jordan, Saudi Arabia and northern Iran on Monday, and Jordan reported another drone being downed on Tuesday.

Many feared trapped in mall as 7.1 quake hits south Japan

AFP & Reuters
letters@hindustantimes.com

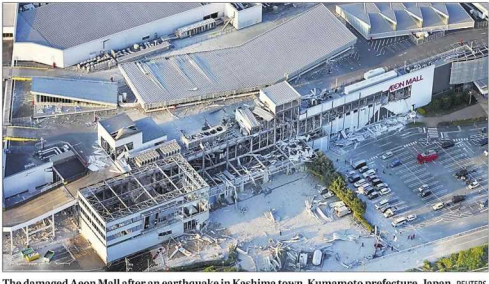
TOKYO: Emergency responders searched early Wednesday for people feared trapped in a shopping mall in southern Japan after a major earthquake toppled buildings, sparked fires and reportedly killed one person and injured more than 100.

Private broadcaster TBS reported that a "considerable number" of people were feared dead inside the mall in the town of Kashima after the fire brigade said that the second floor collapsed in the 7.1-magnitude tremor on Tuesday afternoon.

As night fell, regional officials said they believed 10 people were unaccounted for in the mall, public broadcaster NHK reported. It earlier cited police as saying between 20 and 30 of the mall's employees could not be contacted.

Police told AFP earlier that they could not confirm any fatalities inside the badly damaged building. Kyodo News reported that four people had been taken to hospital, all of them conscious.

Prime Minister Takachi Sanae late Tuesday pledged that emergency responders would work "tirelessly" through the night "starting with the rescue and life-



The damaged Aeon Mall after an earthquake in Kashima town, Kumamoto prefecture, Japan. REUTERS

saving of those affected."

Multiple people were also believed to be unaccounted for at a factory in Yatsushiro city where the tip of a chimney fell down, NHK reported, citing sources.

One person was killed when a house collapsed during the quake, Kyodo reported.

NHK aired footage from elsewhere in the southwestern Kumamoto region on Kyushu island showing several blazes, damaged bridges, a derailed

cargo train and a number of houses threatening to topple over.

The tremor at 4:27pm (0727 GMT) had a magnitude of 7.1, the Japan Meteorological Agency (JMA) said, but reached the highest level of seven on Japan's Shindo scale.

The US Geological Survey put the magnitude at 6.8.

A succession of aftershocks followed, including one with a magnitude of 6.1 at 5:08 pm.

The Japanese military has mobilised 3,600 personnel for disaster relief operations and sent 20 aircraft to assess the damage from the air, the defence minister said. About 45,000 households and facilities had no power in the Kumamoto region, according to local utility Kyushu Electric Power.

The quake's epicentre was about 20 kilometres south of Kumamoto city, central Kyushu's largest city with a population of around 700,000.

737 MAX seats may need inspections: FAA

Reuters
letters@hindustantimes.com

SEATTLE: The US Federal Aviation Administration (FAA) said on Monday that seats on hundreds of Boeing 737 MAX jets registered in the US may require inspections in case they were incorrectly installed and needed to be fixed.

If not corrected, the seats could injure passengers and crew members during an emergency landing or block the aisle and slow an evacuation, the agency said. The FAA's proposed airworthiness directive issued on Monday would apply to 453 jets registered in the US The

agency only has jurisdiction over US airlines, but foreign regulators typically follow FAA directives if applicable.

Nearly 2,300 737 MAX jets are in service around the world, including 823 in the US, according to aviation advisory and intelligence firm IBA. The proposed directive comes as Boeing works to improve its production quality and boost output under CEO Kelly Ortberg. Production quality problems were revealed in early 2024 when a door plug panel blew out of a nearly new Alaska Air 737 MAX in flight.

The FAA said in the airworthiness directive proposal that it received a report that some pas-

senger seat assemblies were not correctly installed in the seat tracks.

That meant the assemblies could disengage from the seat tracks if there was an increased load, turbulence or an emergency landing, the FAA said. There could be up to 69 track-mounted passenger seat assemblies on each 737 MAX plane, and the issue would take an estimated one work hour to inspect and then an hour to fix each assembly and required no parts, the FAA said. Airlines might be able to have multiple employees inspecting seats simultaneously, greatly reducing the total time for each aircraft. It did not say how quickly airlines would need to correct the issue.

A Boeing spokesperson said the planemaker issued guidance to operators about the issue in December 2025.

"We support the FAA making that guidance mandatory," the spokesperson said in an email.



Nearly 2,300 Boeing 737 MAX jets are in service around the world.

X offers banking service to paid Premium users

WASHINGTON: Elon Musk's social media app X on Monday began offering its X Money banking service to all US subscribers of its paid Premium and Premium+ tiers, part of the multi-billionaire's ambition to turn the site into an "everything app". **AFP**

Myanmar approves death sentence for cyber offenders

YANGON: Myanmar's military-backed parliament approved a law on Tuesday authorising capital punishment for those who detain or violently coerce victims into working in online scam centres. Internet fraud factories have flourished in war-torn Myanmar, part of Southeast Asia's thriving scam economy. **AFP**

Tariffs not to hurt US economy, claims Trump

WASHINGTON: President Donald Trump said on Tuesday that the new tariffs imposed by the US on forced labour would not hurt the economy as they would bring billions of dollars in investments. "No, because it's bringing hundreds of billions of dollars," Trump told Fox News. **PTI**

Spain and France race to contain massive wildfires

MADRID/PARIS: Firefighters in Spain and France are racing to contain wildfires threatening Madrid and Bordeaux, as Europe's fourth heatwave of the summer hinders efforts to bring the blazes under control. **BLOOMBERG**

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SPORT

Geneva to host
Gukesh-Sindarov
World C'ship tie

HT Correspondent

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BENGALURU: The Swiss city of Geneva will host the World Chess Championship match between Gukesh D and Javokhir Sindarov scheduled to take place between November 25 - December 15 this year.

Announcing the decision on Tuesday, international chess federation, Fide's interim president Viswanathan Anand said: "Several countries expressed a strong interest in hosting the match, including India, the United States and Cyprus. After carefully considering all the proposals, Fide has decided to stage the match on neutral soil and bring it to Geneva, a city with a historic tradition of bringing nations and cultures together. We look forward to welcoming the global chess community to Switzerland."

Both the defending world champion, Gukesh from India, and the challenger, Sindarov from Uzbekistan will be 20 years old at the time of the match, making it the youngest World Championship face-off in history. The match will consist of 14 classical games; the first player to reach 7.5 points will be declared the winner. If scores are tied, the match will be decided in tiebreaks.

Cyprus, where the 2026 Candidates Tournament took place and was won by Sindarov, is under potential to have been considered as a potential host for the match. However, in the absence of adequate sponsorship, the proposal fell through.

Earlier, Sindarov had said he would prefer to play the match in a "hot country like Cyprus" rather than in cold conditions. Geneva is expected to be chilly, damp, and overcast at that time of year. Compared with much of inland and alpine Switzerland, however, Geneva's climate is relatively mild and not typically subject to harsh winter conditions.



D Gukesh.

Late bloomer Saransh gets
India call-up for Tests in SL

The 33-year-old
Madhya Pradesh
spinner's selection
would give hope
to Ranji performers

Rasesh Mandani

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MUMBAI: As India head to Sri Lanka for a two-Test series in August with renewed hope to keep the World Test Championship dream alive, the squad will include a domestic journeyman with a chance to fulfil a lifelong dream of his and his cricketer father.

If he gets to play, Saransh Jain, 33, will become India's oldest Test debutant after Robin Singh, who made his debut in 1998 aged 35. In his time, Subodh too was an off-spinner for Madhya Pradesh. Now, as a cancer survivor, he would relish the emotional ride of watching his son play for India.

Picking Saransh as a replacement for Washington Sundar - he is ruled out of the first Test with a hamstring injury - is a departure from convention for Ajit Agarkar's selection committee which has been wary of introducing 32-plus players to the international fold.

"It doesn't matter that he is late. It also means he is bringing forth his experience," said Harbhajan Singh, who worked with Saransh recently at a spin bowling camp at BCCI's Centre of Excellence.

"Uski unglin main dum hai, shoulder main jaan hai (there is strength in his fingers and life in the shoulder for a spinner). That's all you want," the former India off-spinner told HT. "Woh paka hua bowler hai (he is a mature bowler). He has bowled a lot of overs in Ranji Trophy. In Indian domestic cricket, you don't get the ball spinning from the first ball. The pitches are not always spin



Saransh Jain during a practice session ahead of a Test against Afghanistan in June.

friendly. I saw watching Saransh that he has the art of picking wickets. You can make out from the first ball... his seam position, accuracy, ability to bowl where he wants, it's all there."

Saransh made his first-class debut as an off-spin all-rounder for MP in 2014, but after years of self-discovery it was in 2021, when Chandrakant Pandit became head

coach, that he found a grip over proceedings. "I felt he had something in him when I first saw him. To give him more opportunities, I had to drop a senior spinner," said Pandit. "I remember in one match Andhra had taken nearly a 150-run lead and he was able to turn the match around and we won outright. It's these performances that convince you."

For long, Saransh had been back in the queue of off-spinners who have had to wait it out while Ravichandran Ashwin spun a web at the highest level. When Ashwin retired during the 2024 Australian tour, the selectors opted for Mumbai's Tanush Kotian for his attributes as a tall off-spinner. Towards the back end of Ashwin's storied career, Sundar had stepped up as

an allround package.

Saransh's classical off-spin bowling, therefore, is somewhat of a throwback. However, he kept reinventing. Pandit recalled how he encouraged Saransh to bowl from around the wicket to the right hander to bring his away going ball into play. He was reluctant initially as every off-spinner about losing out on lbw. But I explained how the slips, leg-slip, short leg could be used. Soon, Rajat Paudyal would end up taking so many catches off Saransh at bat-pad," he said.

The spinner is an outlier on another count. Despite his batting complementing his prime skills, for his orthodox bowling style he has never won favour at the IPL auction table. That took away the possibility of parachuting into top-flight cricket like many others. "I don't want to go to IPL just as a net bowler, but only if I am picked," Pandit recalled Saransh once telling him. "He therefore wanted to work very hard on red-ball cricket. That was his determination. He always wanted to play for India."

That goal is close to bearing fruit. He could find himself competing for a spot in the playing eleven with left-arm spinner Manav Suthar - Ravindra Jadeja and Kuldeep Yadav are expected to start. The tour match on August 7 could thus prove decisive.

Earlier this month, Saransh had impressed for India A with an all-round performance (4/52, 2/56 & 70*) against Sri Lanka A at Galle, where the first Test begins on August 15. The second Test will be played in Colombo from Aug 23. The second: Shubman Gill (C), KL Rahul (VC), Yashasvi Jaiswal, Rishabh Pant (WK), Sai Sudharsan, Dhruv Jurel (WK), Ravindra Jadeja, Kuldeep Yadav, Manav Suthar, Jasprit Bumrah, Mohammed Siraj, Prashidh Krishna, Gurnoor Brar, Devdutt Padikal and Saransh Jain.

HT

Five wicket maidens
in a row for Greaves

TRINIDAD: West Indies all-rounder Justin Greaves made Test history by becoming the first bowler in the recorded era to take wickets in five consecutive maiden overs during the opening Test against Pakistan in Tarouba. The 32-year-old returned figures of 5-27. Greaves surpassed the previous record of four consecutive wicket maidens, set by former England fast bowler Stuart Broad against South Africa in Johannesburg in 2016.

France appoint
Zidane as coach

PARIS: Zinedine Zidane was appointed France coach on Tuesday following the departure of Didier Deschamps, the French Football Federation (FFF) said. Zidane, 54, had long been viewed as the leading candidate for the role and had been waiting for an opportunity to take charge of the national team for several years.

India women beat
Australia 3-2

NEW DELHI: India sealed a 3-2 victory over Australia, with Sutirtha Mukherjee showing remarkable resilience to win a gripping match before Yashaswini Ghorpade held her nerve to clinch the deciding rubber in the second-stage league match of the Commonwealth Table Tennis Championships. Sutirtha fought back from a 1-2 deficit to win in five games and had India a 2-1 lead. Ghorpade then defeated Min Yung Jee in straight games to seal India's 3-2 victory after Sreeja Akula had lost the fourth rubber.

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India's Sarvesh Kushare during the men's high jump final at the Commonwealth Games at Scotstoun Stadium in Glasgow.

Kushare scales a barrier, wins CWG silver medal

The 31-year-old wins high jump silver at CWG, his first major international medal

Avishhek Roy

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NEW DELHI: Sarvesh Kushare went through anxious moments when he twice failed to clear 2.25m. Until then, the high jump national record holder had smoothly cleared every height on first attempt. But with the competition approaching the business end with a medal on the line, Kushare could feel the nerves, with the heart racing.

He calmed himself down to surmount the bar and his jittery heart on his third and last attempt. It eventually secured a silver medal for Kushare, marking the second time an Indian male high jumper was on podium at the Commonwealth Games. Tejswin Shankar had won bronze at 2022 Birmingham.

Jamaican Romaine Beckford also cleared 2.25m, but on his first

attempt which won him gold on countback, England's Kitman Jack took the bronze (2.20m). Both Kushare and Beckford raised the bar to 2.28m but failed to clear it. Kushare's success at a major competition has come after years of grind. The 31-year-old has been painstakingly striving for this breakthrough, adding centimetres to the bar. In the last one year, he has been reaping the rewards of his hard work and everything is coming together. This includes making it to the final at last year's World Championships in Tokyo, where he ended a credible sixth (2.28m). Reaching the final was a first for an Indian high jumper. A third-place finish at the Monaco Diamond League meet (2.26m), where the world's top athletes compete on invitation, was another first in the build-up to CWG.

"Major tournaments like CWG come once in four years, and I am happy to have finally won a medal at a major event. It will push me to do better at the Asian Games and prepare for the Olympics," said Kushare.

"I was clearing every jump on

the first chance, but at 2.25m my rhythm was a bit disturbed. My stride length got shorter. The conditions were slightly cold and keeping my body warm was a bit difficult, but I managed it on the final attempt. It was a good experience," Kushare told PTI in Glasgow.

The target that really pushed Kushare towards bigger laurels was the eight-year-old national record of Tejswin Shankar, which he finally surpassed at the Inter-State Athletics Championships in Bhubaneswar in June. When Kushare cleared 2.30m, it was not just a number but a barrier (2.29m) that he had been chasing for seven years. Kushare has been dominating domestic meets since 2018 and in more than 10 tournaments, after sealing a podium finish, he would stand in front of his goal (2.29m). Sometimes he thought he did everything right only for the slightest grazing of the bar bringing it down. It would be a moment of disappointment before he summed up his resolve back.

"Koi nah, phir karenga (No issue, we'll try again)," Kushare would tell his coach Jithin C Thomas of the Army Sports Institute, and move on to take another attempt at breaking the national record.

Jithin, a former high jumper and National Games medalist, has been training Kushare at ASI Pune since 2022. "It's been a long journey to come so far. We have gone through so many ups and downs, and Sarvesh has fought with his chin up," Jithin told HT from Spala, Poland, where he was with Kushare in the national camp before his protegee left for Glasgow.

Kushare's progression has been slow but steady. In 2019, he cleared 2.28m for the first time, and touched 2.27m at the 2022 National Games. Over the next few years, he stayed steady, qualifying for the Paris Olympics, and kept at it.

"When an athlete reaches his peak, sometimes stagnancy comes because he has to work harder from that level. We focused on strength and conditioning so that he could take more load. We fine-tuned his technique, run-up—all

these things add to the performance," said Jithin.

"With his height (1.79m or 5'10") and body weight, clearing 2.27m or 2.28m was impressive, but to go beyond that he has to be outstanding, and do it repeatedly. It requires more effort. You have to have patience and ensure there is no injury," said Jithin.

"We kept trying and worked towards healthy progress. Sarvesh is so dedicated and disciplined in his work ethic and is extremely positive." In Glasgow, when Kushare was fighting self-doubt and struggling to keep himself warm in slightly cold conditions, he was encouraged by Tejswin. Unfortunately, Tejswin pulled out after one attempt—failed at 2.05m—due to a last-minute flare-up of an issue with his patellar tendon. The 2022 Commonwealth Games bronze medalist took an attempt, but fell pain in his knee and withdrew. However, he interacted with Kushare and egged him on from the sidelines.

It will be tough for Tejswin to recover quickly and get ready for decathlon in two days.

RESULTS (INDIANS ONLY)

ATHLETICS

Women's shot put F57 final
Sharmila won gold
Shilpa Shyla won bronze
Men's high jump final
Sarvesh Kushare won silver
Men's 100m T38 final
Rakesh Bhatt finished 5th
Shreyansh Trivedi finished 6th
Men's 110m hurdles final
Tejas Shirshe finished 8th
Men's 400m Round 1
Vishal TK qualified for semi-final
Rajesh Ramesh failed to qualify for semi-final

BOWLS

Men's pairs, Group B
India bt Cook Islands via tiebreaker

BOXING

Women's 54kg quarter-final



Preeti Pawar bt Nicole Clyde (NIR) 5-0

Women's 60kg quarter-final

Priya Ganghag bt Niamh Mitchell (SCO) 4-1

Women's 65kg quarter-final

Parveen Hooda lost to Sacha Hickey (ENG) 3-2

Men's 55kg quarter-final

Jadumani Singh Mandegham bt Mwenge Mwale (ZAM) 5-0

Men's 55kg quarter-final

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THE WEEK THAT WAS

A quiz on the week's development.



Ajaya Babu wins silver in men's weightlifting

Agencies

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GLASGOW: Indian weightlifter Valluri Ajaya Babu produced a remarkable performance to win silver in the men's 79kg category at the CWG. The 21-year-old from Andhra Pradesh's Vizianagaram lifted a Games record 149kg in snatch and 181kg in clean and jerk for a total of 330kg to win the second prize, narrowly missing out on gold to Malaysia's Erry Hidayat Muhammad, who totalled a Games record 331kg (147 + 184) on Monday night.

This was India's sixth medal in weightlifting in the current edition of the Games.

Nirupama Devi however endured a forgettable campaign, managing just one successful lift from six attempts as she failed to register a total in the women's 63kg on Tuesday. The 25-year-old completed only a 93kg snatch. Needing a stronger clean and jerk, she opted for an ambitious 123kg and failed. Tokyo Olympic champion and Paris Games silver medalist Canada's Maude Charbon clinched the gold with a Games record effort of 232kg (102kg+130kg).

Vishal qualifies

National record holder in men's 400m Vishal TK, qualified for the semi-finals, while compatriot Rajesh Ramesh missed the cut. The 22-year-old Vishal from Tamil Nadu, who became the first Indian to dip below the 45-second barrier with his national record of 44.98 seconds in May this year, finished second in Round 1 Heat 6 with a time of 46.49 seconds. He crossed the line behind Alim Glasgow of St Vincent and the Grenadines, who won the heat in 46.03 seconds, with the top two athletes from Heat 6 progressing to the



Valluri Ajaya Babu.

semi-finals. Running in Heat 3, Rajesh clocked 47.43 seconds to finish third and bowed out.

Overall, Vishal's 46.49 was the 14th fastest among the 16 semi-finalists. The semifinals will be on July 30. Jamaica's Zandrian Barnes emerged as the quickest qualifier after posting 45.33 seconds in Heat 4.

Srihari Nataraj in semis

Srihari Nataraj qualified for the 100m backstroke semi-finals but Sajjan Prakash failed to go past the heats of 50m butterfly.

Nataraj finished fifth in his Heat and 13th overall with a timing of 55.58 seconds. The 16 fastest swimmers move ahead from the preliminary stage. The semifinals will be held later tonight.

Nataraj, whose timing at the 50m mark was 26.26sec, has a personal best of 53.77 seconds, which is also the national record that he created in 2021.

Sajan, however, failed to qualify after finishing eighth in his Heat and 18th overall.

The 32-year-old, who was part of the ninth and final group, clocked 24.94 seconds to bow out of contention. The effort was well below his personal best of 23.83 seconds, also a national record.

GLASGOW CORNER

'ARSHAD READY FOR QUALIFIERS'

Defending CwG javelin champion Arshad Nadeem has put behind a difficult build-up caused by inclement weather in Switzerland and is "all keyed up" for the qualification round, his long-time coach Salman Butt said on Tuesday. Arshad, Pakistan's brightest medal hope at the Games, finished ninth at the Lucerne Silver Meet in Switzerland earlier this month but has since adapted to the conditions in Glasgow ahead of the qualifiers on July 30. The reigning Olympic champion struggled to find his rhythm in Switzerland after arriving directly from a training camp in Lahore. "He is all keyed up for the qualifiers and wants to do well again in this competition," Butt said. India will field Neeraj Chopra, Rohit Yadav and Yash Vir Singh in the event.

FLOODS: LOVLINA APPEALS FOR HELP

Olympic bronze medalist Lovlina Borgohain said she has been unable to fully focus on her CWG campaign because of the devastating floods in Assam, and appealed to people to extend help to those affected. The 28-year-old boxer from Assam is assured of at least a bronze medal after receiving a direct entry into the women's 75kg semifinals because of the five-box draw. "I am feeling very bad that a lot of people have lost their lives because of the flood in Assam. A lot of people are facing a lot of problems at this time," said Borgohain, who became only the third Indian boxer to win an Olympic medal when she claimed bronze in Tokyo, in a video message.

Grit and glory: Shot putter Sharmila beats odds for gold

Shantanu Srivastava

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NEW DELHI: Some stories write themselves, and Sharmila Dhankar's gritty journey of fortune and resilience is one of them. The celebration of her rise from the lowest point of burnishes her achievement. The 39-year-old from Chitiholi village in Haryana's Mahendragiri district achieved a grand high on a chilly Monday evening at the Commonwealth Games in Glasgow.

Competing in the para shot put F57 event, Sharmila hurled the 3kg iron ball the farthest (8.81m) in the field, becoming India's first CWG gold medalist in para athletics.

Her season's best effort also made her the first Indian woman to win a para athletics medal at the Games. Compatriot Shilpa Shyla was awarded the bronze (7.26m) following a protest. Nigeria's Eugenia Iyari looked set to take the third spot, but her final attempt was ruled a foul after Sharmila drew the attention of the officials, leading to Shilpa's ejection.

"I noticed Iyari's feet move while throwing and her belt wasn't fastened properly either, all of which constitutes a foul. I took it up with technical officials who reviewed her throw and ruled it illegal," Sharmila told HT from Glasgow in an interaction facilitated by SAT. Sharmila, who boasts of a personal best of 10.03m achieved at the 2025 World Para Athletics Championships in New Delhi, produced a series of 9.48m, 9.58m, 9.81m, 9.17m, 9.37m and 9.60m. Such was her dominance that any of her efforts could've fetched her gold. Ghana's Zinaisa Issah (8.65m) took silver.

"The feeling is yes to sink in. I



India's Sharmila Dhankar (L) and Shilpa Shyla.

hear there were celebrations in my village. My daughters are proud of me. What else can I ask?" she gushed.

Second among four siblings, Sharmila was born to an impoverished household. Her father was a small-time farmer and her blind mother had the onerous task of raising the children. "There were days when we barely had enough to eat," she said. Sharmila contracted polio at the age of two, which meant much of her childhood was spent fielding blows from friends and acquaintances besides enduring the physical disadvantage.

"She was married off at 19—because that's how it is in our

parts"—and things went worse. Her husband, who she chose not to name, often beat her mercilessly.

"It started sporadically, and then it became the norm. He would get drunk and thrash me. First it was about driving, then for giving birth to girls. There were times I thought of ending my life," said Sharmila, a mother to two daughters. The abuse went on for seven years and things reached a tipping point when one day her husband threw her out of their house with his daughters.

"That's when my family brought me home and decided not to go back to that man." Sharmila re-married two years

later to Ajit, a mechanic with limited means, who accepted her daughters and "motivated me to do something with my life."

Encouraged by this, Sharmila enrolled at the Rao Tularam Stadium near their home in Rewari in 2020. She was 34. "Most athletes retire at that age, and here I was, looking for a fresh start."

She trained under Tek Chand, a bronze medalist in the F54/55 shot put at the 2018 Asian Para Games. Two years on, she was at the Birmingham CWG, where she finished fourth. Another fourth-place finish followed at the 2023 Asian Para Games. "I was not happy with the results, and looking at the sacrifices my family was making, I felt an overpowering sense of guilt," she said, recalling days when her husband and daughters went empty stomach to ensure she got her fill. After her father passed away in 2023, Sharmila's mother sold their small patch of land for ₹24 lakh to fund her daughter's career. Ajit joined in, selling their 25 square yard house in Sonapat for ₹10 lakh.

"They wanted me to excel at the 2025 Worlds, but a fifth-place finish is all I could manage," she said. "That's why, my only target this time was gold. I couldn't have settled for anything else." Her daughters have taken after their mother. The 15-year-old Anuj trains in javelin while 13-year-old Lakshmi is trying out long jump.

The mother and daughters now train and dream together. "I dream of competing in the next CWG with my daughters," she said. "There's also the Asian Para Games and Paralympics coming up, and the target once again will be gold."

"I want women to find strength to fight domestic abuse. Don't be scared, take your chances and life might just turn around."

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